Revival! The Uluru Games

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Roller Coaster

RUG-01

Answering Machine: G'day, you've reached Desert Flannel.

Answering Machine: I'm not home right now, or I don't have time for calls. Please leave a message after the "beep."

Answering Machine: Hello? We've only got 20 minutes before the game starts! Where are you?

Answering Machine: Get your ass here now, unless you're dead!

Answering Machine: Look, look, I know you're not into these games, but you can really use the money, right? Otherwise, you wouldn't have come to me!

Not a single beam of light can pass through the thick blackout curtain. Blocked out by it is a perfect sunny day.

Desert Flannel: Emm ...

Answering Machine: If you stand me up again, we're both screwed!

Desert Flannel: Urrhh ... Emm, whatever ... Just leave it to Thursday.

Answering Machine: The game on Thursday is crucial. I will get expelled if I mess it up! I'm begging you, d**n it! Just come over NOW!

Desert Flannel: Thur ... Thursday?

Between the quilt and the bed, the bipedal animal is struggling to come back to the waking world.

Desert Flannel: Wait. It's Thursday?!

The word is like a head-on shocking blow.

She has missed out on so many things.

A similar misfortune befalls someone else, too.

Vertin: We missed the right junction. The roads are different from the map Mr. Slouch Hat gave us.

Vertin: It's too outdated to provide any useful information.

Medicine Pocket: Terrific! We've gone wrong again. This is like ... yeah, the fourth time.

Medicine Pocket: Since my short life is supposed to be spent in creating huge value for all the living things in this world ...

Medicine Pocket: The Foundation should have sent me another bodyguard—a more reliable one! And the contact here should have offered us a more reliable map!

Vertin: I am the one and only reliable "bodyguard" who can keep you safe among all the others in the Foundation.

Vertin: You are of great significance to Laplace. They don't want you to take any risks.

Cities always change, and maps are supposed to follow them in step.

Vertin: We can go back to the last junction or keep going forward. There is a trail about 300 meters ahead, and it leads all the way to the Rolling Croc Bookstore.

Vertin: You want to check the map?

Medicine Pocket: When things don't work out one way, a researcher will find another.

Medicine Pocket: See, there comes another way!

The girl coming around from the corner is the perfect choice.

Medicine Pocket: Hey, wait! Ms. Spa-Spathodea, right?

Spathodea: Umm ... Hmm? Who are you?

Spathodea: Umm, do I know you?

With sweat on the tip of her nose, she keeps hopping on the spot.

A Bestie Badge with her name on it is pinned to her chest. Clearly, she is not aware of what gives her away.

Choices

1. No, I don't think so.

2. Do you know the Rolling Croc Bookstore?

Branch 1

Vertin: We arrived in Australia not long ago.

Medicine Pocket: But we've been lost for way too long, so long that the human society has begun to suffer economic losses because I've been loafing around.

Medicine Pocket holds the girl on her shoulders and slightly shakes her body.

Medicine Pocket: Now, you are given an opportunity to help the whole of humanity, and it only takes a few minutes, well, maybe hours, of your meaningless life—Take us to the Rolling Croc.

Branch 2

Vertin: Excuse us, we're looking for a bookstore.

Vertin: It's called the Rolling Croc, with a hand drum made of crocodile skin hanging on the signboard.

Medicine Pocket: And that very store has the fragment of the fungus potion analysis report I want.

Medicine Pocket: If it weren't for that, no one would've taken a walk on this ridiculously vast land, no one! Besides, there is no Frisbee here.

Shared continuation

Spathodea: The Rolling Croc? Rolling ... Oh! I pass by that store every morning when I exercise!

Spathodea: Go straight ahead, turn right into the lane after passing by a cafe with an orange signboard, and there it is! But do keep your heads down, or you'll be hit by the signboards there.

Spathodea: I can take you there if you need ... Oh, shoot!

Beep. Beep beep.

Spathodea: Warm-up time is almost over. I have to go! My coach is waiting for me for the punching exercise. Sorry guys, hope you find the store!

Vertin: Thank you. Hmm?

Desert Flannel: Make way! Make way! Move aside!

Spathodea: It's okay. Don't mention it!

The girl is setting out again. Her crisp voice overlaps the approaching shouting.

Vertin: Wait!

Vertin: Someone's at the corner! Watch ...

Desert Flannel: Errrahh!

Spathodea: H-Help! Urgh! Ugh ....

Vertin: Ugh ...

Spathodea: ... Fire? I'm ... on fire ...

Vertin: Confusion and weak pulse ... We have to take her to Laplace.

Spathodea: I ... Mmm ... Uhh ...

Bedroom

Spathodea: I-I'm fine! I'm always fine.

Spathodea: *deep breath*

Tossing and turning.

Spathodea: What happened to me? Did I really break some part of myself?

Spathodea: They said I passed out, but it doesn't feel like that to me. My vest is dusted, but I don't feel any pain at all.

She tosses around in bed, crumpling the bed sheet like wadded-up tissues.

Spathodea: Maybe I need more ice water?

She gulps down some cold water.

Spathodea: Mmm. No, maybe it's hot tea that I need.

And takes a sip of boiling hot black tea.

Spathodea: Uh ... Shoot, it's not working at all!

Spathodea: I should have gone to that "Lap-lettuce" with those wacky people and had a physical examination. Let me see, their card is in ... Wait, no!

Spathodea: I've turned them down. If I go back to them, ugh, that will be super embarrassing!

Spathodea: Besides, I bumped my head on the ground, but it's my stomach that is feeling sick now. I'm sure this is just a coincidence.

Spathodea: I-I seldom have junk food, and never miss the training at school! I know my body well. It's healthy! And tough!

She says so to comfort herself, shaking her head and pulling out a photo album from under the pillow.

Spathodea: I already took the medicine for stomach pain. Now just take a break and distract myself from it.

The moment she opens the album, a breeze blows out from it.

Spathodea: *deep breath* The smell of soil, mineral, burning coal, and the golden penda.

Spathodea: That already makes me feel much better.

Everyone has their own way to chill out, so does Spathodea.

She eagerly draws in the breeze, running her finger along the edge of the photos. In one of the photos, an arcanist with rosy cheeks is flying on a broom, cheering for her victory.

Spathodea: This is the first photo in my collection. Mom gave it to me for my fifth birthday.

Spathodea: In 1884, Branch Vault was very popular among arcanists. The Uluru Games that year had more trees than that in any other years.

Spathodea: Then in 1900, St. Pavlov Foundation took over the Uluru Games.

Spathodea: Out of security concerns, they abolished one third of the events that involved dangerous actions and imposed a lot of regulations on the rest. Jones got first place in the game that year.

Spathodea: Then, the Games in 1938. It was the most successful one ever since the Foundation took over.

Spathodea: It was so successful almost everyone thought the Games would be revived and brought back to the public, until ...

A slight sigh escapes her mouth. Now, she is looking at the last page of the thin album.

Spathodea: I wish I could see the Uluru Stadium with my own eyes again, even for just a minute.

Spathodea: Like ... like how I used to host the opening ceremonies in there.

Spathodea: Back then, I stood on the highest platform, igniting a flame from the wood saturated by ointment, and then flew on a rosewood branch, following a canoe in water and gently pushing it forward.

Spathodea: But the flame had a fight with me. I trembled with anger because ... she was such an unreasonable blockhead. Then, my sight was filled with darkness.

Spathodea: My sight?

Spathodea: MY SIGHT?!

Spathodea unconsciously scratches her chest, and then her throat.

Spathodea: Did I just say something? What are these things doing in my head? Are they illusions?

Spathodea: When did I go to the desert? Since when did I ... ugh ... *coughs*

A warm touch of itch climbs up from her stomach to her chest, squeezing itself out of her windpipe.

Like a bird fluffing its damp feathers, struggling its way out from her body.

Spathodea: Mmm. Is the medicine working? My stomach is much better now, but my throat ... It's, burning and itchy.

Spathodea: *retches* ... *coughs and gasps*

Spathodea: *coughs* ... Ughhh ...

Spathodea: *vomits*

Spathodea: M-Mom ...

Spathodea: M-M-Mom never told me ... w-w-we are descendants of the Red Dragon ...

Spathodea: No ... No no no no! I need to see the doctor right now!

5#1

The Torch Guardians V

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

The Torch Guardians VI

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

End of Rumors

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Face Yourself

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Event Program

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List of Uluru Games Sporting Events (Provisional Version)

Arcanum-Themed Events

[Track and Field]

The use of arcane skills, such as vaporization, blink, and flying, is permitted.

Potions and special vehicles are strictly prohibited. Requires implementable drug testing procedures to be designed. For example, random sampling before the start of the competition and standardized drug testing procedures for the top six athletes in each event after the competition.

The world record for this event was set by Carlos Castillo, the Cuban flying mouse, in 1924. By the time of his retirement, he was still unable to break his own record.

Mr. Pavia once surpassed this height in training—I witnessed it with my own eyes! I'm really looking forward to seeing him perform out on the field.

There are still uncertainties regarding the distinctions between certain vehicle drivers and the vehicles themselves, such as participants racing in vehicles like UFOs, wooden horses, and artificial satellites.

The individual event rules will provide more detailed information on this situation to avoid any potential complications regarding the referee's decision-making duties.

[Combat Events]

The competition venue needs to be set up next to a medical station.

Guardrails and warning lines need to be placed around the arena to prevent excited spectators from entering the field of competition and disrupting the competition schedule.

Competitors must tame strange water beasts, mount them, and race them. Druids will be allowed to participate.

Algae needs to be planted at the water area's endpoint to maintain the physical condition and hemoglobin index of the beasts.

The Nagger Weekend Special

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The Nagger Weekend Special

Exclusive Exposé: Revival Squad and Bunny Girl Cause Commotion at City Hall! Civil Servants Suffer Mental Breakdown Due to Extreme Intimidation

The Uluru Games are on the verge of revival, igniting the flame of competition in arcanists everywhere.

I'm sure many of you have heard the news already—perhaps you've even passed by the "Revival Squad" in the street, led by that precocious female student—and needless to say, everyone is very curious about them. They are, of course, a flame, a ninth-grade student, a fungus researcher, and a prominent public figure backed by the entire St. Pavlov Foundation, making for a motley crew fascinating enough to make anyone's heart burst with excitement.

Just like the Bunyips, who have been seen lurking in the city's dark alleys recently, these denizens of society's dark underbelly have crawled out of the sewers and thrust themselves into the spotlight, and are fast captivating the entire nation's imagination and attention.

"Following closely behind a bunny girl, a mad scientist, giant brown mushrooms, and Pixel Emu in tow, does the Melbourne shuffle by the fireside."

Where could you possibly hope to see such a scene? In a science fiction movie? At the circus? In your dreams, perhaps? No—this all happened at Alice Springs City Hall. This scene of pure absurdity was also the first impression a bystander (who has asked to be referred to here as "Ms. Kate") had of the Revival Squad.

We… We have undertaken all manner of large events and functions, all on behalf of guests with etiquette and a sense of propriety. But they… they're just too much! They… Oh my goodness… My upbringing doesn't permit me to repeat the things they did, please understand."

The aforementioned chaos wrought by the Revival Squad completely destroyed "Ms. Kate's" day. When recounting this experience, she choked back tears multiple times and even broke out in incoherent sobs.

Let us return to that glorious event and reflect on what our ancestors had to say about the "Uluru Games." Do we really need these games? Or did someone tell you that you need them to awaken the love for sportsmanship and fair competition lying dormant in your heart? What is the point of them? Selling tickets? Is this just another case of sensationalism gone mad?

Go and take a look at the page you just tore out of your calendar this morning—as we stand at the end of the century, who truly wishes to exhume those long-dead and decadent traditions once again? Whose pockets are being lined with the money from these tickets that seem to be on sale everywhere you go?

—Yes, we have all the answers you've been looking for!

Reporter: Makower
— Nagger Weekend Special Edition #136

Australian Nagger — Your personal private eye!

Australian Journal of Biological Behavior

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Australian Journal of Biological Behavior

A Study on the Effect of Changes in Water Temperature on the Bunyip's Lie Detection Mechanism

[Experimental Samples]

1. Twelve adult Bunyips, numbered YP-01 to YP-12, each approximately ten feet long, divided into two groups, A and B, with six in each group and with a balanced gender ratio.

2. Three human volunteers, numbered V1, V2, and V3.

3. Two large enclosed aquariums capable of accommodating a total of twelve Bunyips.

4. Three color picture cards placed in a sealed, unlit box depicting apples, bananas, and pears, respectively.

[Method]

1. Place the 12 Bunyips from groups A and B into their corresponding aquariums while ensuring freshwater quality and oxygen quantity are consistent. Ensure that Group A's water temperature is set to 14 degrees centigrade and that Group B's is set to 32 degrees centigrade.

2. Direct V1 to enter the room and select one of the picture cards from the sealed box at random without showing it to the two groups of Bunyips.

3. V1 then describes the selected fruit on the picture card to the two groups of Bunyips. This description can be true or false. To avoid the personal traits of individual volunteers affecting the results, the voices of the volunteers must be altered and the volume unified.

4. Record the physiological responses of the two groups of Bunyips, including dorsal fin vibration frequency, heart rate changes, and body temperature.

5. Replace the volunteer and repeat steps 2-4.

6. Determine the authenticity of the content described by volunteers via hidden camera recordings.

7. Compare the differences in physiological responses to true and false descriptions between the two groups of Bunyips.

[Results]

1. When volunteers provided authentic descriptions, both groups of Bunyips remained calm.

2. When volunteers provided false descriptions, dorsal fin vibration frequency and heart rate in both groups of Bunyips increased significantly.

3. Both groups of Bunyips could sensitively distinguish between the behavior of humans when lying and when telling the truth through physiological responses, and the higher the water temperature, the more sensitive the Bunyips became.

[Conclusion and Prospective Optimizations]

The individual YP-07 in Aquarium B showed significant physiological deviation in its responses. Through retrospective analysis, we found that regardless of whether the description provided by the volunteers was false or not, YP-07 was more likely to believe that the picture cards drawn depicted bananas. Whether this is because the individual concerned prefers bananas or because the high water temperature affected YP-07's judgment in a way that made YP-07 more willing to believe that the fruit on the card was of a tropical nature has yet to be determined. Follow-up research will expand and optimize the current experimental setup based on these two assumptions in order to study the correlation between them.

Excerpt from Indigenous Sports

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Excerpt from Indigenous Sports

Running tracks, ball courts, and lawns—these places are where key memories in an individual's journey of growth are born.

At every moment—every second throughout history—people have been competing, running, striking, and jumping somewhere in this land. It was through friendly competition and childish games, throwing stones and tree seeds, that children learned the basics of hunting. As they grew older, they would climb tree trunks to pick wild fruit and hone their nimble movements and footing. The youth walked upon redwood branches, placing stones on their knees, then sought to catch the most dazzling sparks from the fire.

"Tree seeds, trunks, and branches. It is from the top of a eucalyptus tree that our lives can be seen." This is the old saying that accompanies the tradition of the arcanists.

Arcanists journeyed through dense forests and rivers, hiking to reach the belly of the earth—Uluru.

Uluru Games Compendium P7

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Uluru Games Compendium P7

A photograph of Samantha Green in the 500-Meter Water Beast Steeplechase, 1921. Artificially colorized.

The world champion of the 500-meter water beast steeplechase defended her title for three consecutive events. The water beast yielded at her feet like a timid little kitten. But is it really possible for anyone to get along with water beasts this effortlessly? Does water beast blood in fact flow through her veins? All very good questions, but I'll tell you now, it's very likely. Note well, I'll be telling Mia the truth behind this secret next week.

A photograph of Sophie Rogers in the Incantation Duel, 1922. Well preserved.

Although there was some controversy over the refereeing in her retirement competition, it did not impede Sophie Rogers's smooth induction into the Hall of Fame.

She pioneered the strategy of using levitation techniques and telekinesis incantations to launch defensive counterattacks, becoming an idol to the young generation at the time.

A photograph of Benjamin Stone in the Team Dressage Competition, 1918. Slightly damaged.

The Ocean Circus, led by Benjamin Stone, became the dark horse in this year's team dressage event. In the semi-finals, they toppled the dominant position of local frontrunners, the Kangaroo Mounted Rangers. Who would have thought they could reach such a seamless degree of understanding with their seahorses?

Research Springboard

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You are back here again.

Maybe it's telepathy. Maybe your soul is out of your body. Maybe … Anyway, you're back here. In the dark woods, the huge oak trees crack in front of you. Dry and pungent fumes billow out.

Flames swallow a lot of things: a lot of money, a lot of lives, family laughters, and a pair of eyes that once looked to the future.

Choices

1. What's the smell?

2. It feels like …

Branch 1

Gasoline. The turf here is tan and shiny. The clump looks like an uneven asphalt road.

After so long, I mean, so many days, probably years, the fumes are still as pungent as yesterday. It won't take eight hours for your eyes to tingle.

There's no boundary for the burned woods. You can hardly tell between the dark night and the scorched woods. To create such a huge, amazing fire … will a small barrel of gasoline simply be enough?

I'm afraid even 50 barrels are barely enough.

Branch 2

Dead skin. Dead fish. Upturning fishy scales. Desperate, the wailing wails of aquatic animals being boiled in the sea.

Your palm tingles as you caress the trunk. The tree trunks with hanging dried strips of bark look like frightened cats—this might be their last effort to retain their dignity before meeting their doom. The hanging bark falls to the ground at your touch. No muss. No fuss. As if they've prepared for the fall for a long time.

The woods are no fan of the fire. But they don't like staying on the cross for a long time either.

You still have so many questions to ask her.

But before you could, the battle has started.

Choices

1. I still got a chance to ask her.

I like you being positive. Your optimism will help you achieve your goals, get with the impossible girls, pay the bills, and probably become the greatest pacifist!

Oh, did I just mention the girls? Just in case, I need to add a few more, so get with the impossible girls, boys, elders, transgenders, cute radios, ass heads ...

Enough. What we said tonight is just between you and me.

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.

The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.

Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

List of Accompanying Sprays

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List of Accompanying Sprays

[Formula]

Add a small amount of rough cocklebur extract and maidenhair fern powder to a chanterelle base.

The soluble green pigment in the rough cocklebur's fruiting body gives the spray a bright green appearance, and its smell also helps to mask the slightly bitter taste of the maidenhair fern powder.

[Application]

Clinical use should pay attention to dosage control, as high doses may lead to excessive sedation, confusion, and sleep disorders such as drowsiness.

The spray is also often used in specific spiritual rituals to achieve the purpose of deep meditation and relaxation.

Being highly compatible, the addition of other nutrients can be considered according to the circumstances of usage and the patient's metabolic level to enrich its functional effects.

[Formula]

The spores of umbrella jelly fungus are used as the main raw material.

A suitable amount of lavender essence is also added to the formula.

The fruiting body of umbrella jelly fungus contains fluorescein, while the aroma of lavender can soothe the patient's stress.

[Application]

The spray forms a layer of biofilm on the cotton filter, which generates a color reaction with the patient's exhalations.

After chromatographic analysis, the patient's physical condition can be preliminarily identified, providing benchmark data for subsequent diagnosis, treatment, and observation.

Commonly used in children, pregnant women, and patients with limited mobility due to trauma.

[Usage Method]

Open the safety valve. Align with the source of the fire and press to spray. Foam will quickly form a mob of kangaroos to isolate the oxygen and extinguish the fire.

[Composition]

Each "foam kangaroo" is milky white in color and composed of small bubbles. Each charming kangaroo structure constitutes a complete bubble membrane.

The "foam kangaroo" targets a fixed point at the flame's edge, thus making it suitable for indoor fires and complex building structures.

[Iterations]

The Kangaroo Foam No. 3 Fire Extinguisher is a standard public safety implement of the Australian branch of Laplace. The Kangaroo Foam No. 3 Fire Extinguisher demonstrates major strides in innovation with regard to the appearance of its "foam kangaroos" to avoid any risk of copyright infringement on the previous version. Compared to the previous versions 1 and 2, there is no significant difference in functionality.

Source of Rumors

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

Research Notes

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Research Notes

> Name: White Milk Mushroom
>
> Its introduction in the guidebook states that it is also known as the spicy milk mushroom. Is it really that spicy? I don't think I want to find out.
>
> Discovery: This mushroom was discovered at the foot of the Dandenong Ranges, in the shade beside a stream. To prevent it from drying out, I placed it in a cloche and brought it home with me.
>
> External Appearance: The cap is semispherical in shape and has a diameter of approximately 3 centimeters. Its appearance is very unique, with soft gills and a cap and stem as white as snowflakes. Unfortunately, it only grows at the foot of the ranges, not on their sometimes snowy peaks. Beneath its cap lie many small spore sacs, which, when opened, reveal spores of a creamy hue.
>
> Tissue Sample: I cut off a small piece, and when observing it under a microscope, could see that the pileus was tender and the curved hyphae were thick and wavy or annular. The structure is very similar to other milk-caps, with differences mainly reflected in color and mycelial morphology.
>
> Function:
>
> 1. Edibility
>
> Being a wild mushroom, it can be eaten raw or used as a cooking ingredient. Even after being sliced, its milk-white juice retains its inherently spicy flavor, stimulating the appetite and thus making it suitable for use as a seasoning.
>
> I'll take good care of it—whether for research or as an emergency food reserve, should the need arise.
>
> 2. Medicinal Value
>
> White milk mushroom extract boasts anti-inflammatory and antioxidant pharmacological properties. Its polysaccharides and peptide components are used in anti-inflammatory drugs, and their inhibitory effects on tumor cells are also used in adjuvant therapy for malignant

tumors. White milk mushrooms can enhance the body's immune system and enhance athletic performance. *Does this mean arcanists can use it as a nutritional supplement?

I'll make a note of this—I need to gather more data.

3. Environmental Indication

The white milk mushroom is highly sensitive to its growing environment; thus, its growth status can provide a preliminary reflection of a forest's ecological health. This has caused it to become one of the ecological indicators for environmental assessment.

Humidity, nitrogen, and pH level are all indicators that correspond to the growth status of white milk mushrooms.

*This was an oversight on my part—I only recorded the growth location but forgot to test the environmental indicators. Treat this as a lesson and be more careful in the future.

Dusty Tickets

小径

Dusty Tickets

A crumpled ticket stub, covered in creases and water marks. The handwriting on the front of it has become blurred.

Australian ■■■■■ Football Championship — Preliminaries

■■■■ Sailors VS Hobart Lakers

Match Time: Saturday 3rd ■■■■■ 19■■ - 19:30.

Ticket Type: B Seat ■■■216

Ticket Price: $19.99

Points for Attention:

1. Please keep your ticket safe and present it upon entry.

2. Dangerous and flammable materials are strictly prohibited from the venue.

3. Minors must be accompanied by ■■■■■■.
4. Before and after the competition, ■■■■■■■■■■ and competition staff will guide spectators in entering and exiting the venue in an orderly manner.

■■■kets are available in limited quantities. Fortunately, ■■■■■■

The ticket stub was crudely torn off here.

A Work Log

小径

A Work Log

When they gave me this civil service job, I never thought I'd end up working with an emu one day.

Or perhaps I should say that when I was drowning in those irrigation project application forms

I couldn't finish last month (there are always so many applications I can't seem to finish), I never thought an emu formed of pixels would be of any use to me…

But… But "Plappy" really is something else. I'm not even sure if that's its name; I just heard that girl with the ponytail call it that.

It's quiet, strong, and has a strangely trustworthy air about it, so when I noticed it flipping through unapproved forms and trying to help with them, I didn't think to stop it.

To be honest, and I'm not sure if I'm just imagining this, but I think I can sense an aura of guilt radiating from Plappy.

It's like the kind of guilt a mother clad in a polka dot skirt feels after her child's soccer ball smashes through a glass window—the sense of guilt felt by a grandmother wearing a woolen beret after her grandchildren ride their bicycles over a beautiful flowerbed. Anyway, I can always count on it to bring me a basket of golden apples, appearing at my door, then bowing down—all the way to the ground.

I know this all seems a little over-the-top, but whether it's true or my imagination, I have managed to calm down the "Revival Squad" formed by those rambunctious children.

Oh, that's right! I mustn't forget to return Kate's backpack. She left it at my house when she came to the housewarming party earlier. She took her sick leave immediately after and won't be at the office for two weeks straight. I saw her today—she looked good and seemed to be preparing for an interview… It's strange… Who would want to interview a civil servant? Maybe I should ask her the next time I see her.

"A Chance Encounter"

小径

"A Chance Encounter"

Plappy: *raises its head*
Plappy: —Hoo-goo!
Bunyip: *raises its forelimbs and slowly approaches*
Bunyip: Hisss—
Plappy: *takes a step back, then stops and observes*
Plappy: Goo-goo!
Bunyip: *rolls sideways*
Bunyip: Groo— Groo-hoo—
Plappy: *flutters its wings*
Bunyip: *lifts its front paws*
Bunyip: Woo-ha—!
Plappy: *tilts its head and touches the Bunyip's paw*
Plappy: —Goo.
Bunyip: *circles Plappy, shaking its head rapidly*
Bunyip: Hisss— Gaa.

A Plea of Innocence

小径

Mrs. Greco puts down the phone. She is now as calm as any Italian mother you've ever met. You know, they're usually making a yummy pie before they pull out their guns.

There are enough people in black outside, enough to prevent any eavesdropping or violent conflict.

Mrs. Greco glanced blandly over the one, two, three, four ... nine, ten, eleven children in front of her. This is a big family, and it has grown bigger and bigger over the past few years because of Schneider.

Choices

1. Who are they?

2. Who is Mrs. Greco?

Branch 1

They're Schneider's sisters. It's hard for the Grecos to tell them apart. But Schneider is different.

But Schneider is different. She was born in an earthquake, all covered in blood, and didn't let out her first cry until two hours later. It wasn't until she was one year old that her father noticed that she had never been baptized.

Branch 2

She's Schneider's biological mother. You see her furrowed face, like a hard stone wall, while inside the wall is all about a pious farmer's life.

The Grecos are not good at dealing with gang affairs. They can't even figure out when their daughter has grown—grown into the backbone of the whole family.

When Schneider took out 500 dollars from her pocket and put them on the table, they were completely shocked, and that's just the beginning.

Schneider ... Schneider, the youngest daughter they seldom cared about. It's impossible to keep every child well-fed. Schneider could not even get a piece of bread in the Eucharist.

But a good daughter would not let anyone worry about her. She sat on the bench outside the church and hummed. She found a way out for herself. She walked to the underground market, fascinated by what she saw ...

She announced her "new identity" one day.

Choices

1. What "new identity"?

2. What bread?

Branch 2.1

The identity you know now.

In the process, she lost something old but gained something new, no matter if she wished for it or not.

Branch 2.2

The bread provided in some sacred religious ceremonies. According to different teachings, it's sometimes flatbread, sometimes fermented bread, or sometimes any kind of bread.

"Now," Mrs. Greco said, "we live, or we die. If Schneider comes back safely tonight ... we will leave when the moon rises."

"The doors are closing in front of us, one after another. But the benevolent Maria will give us the ultimate shelter. My children, remember today forever."

Her words speak for her status. But Mrs. Greco's eyes never moved away from that small Madonna on the table. The hem of her clothes were soaked in tears.

4 p.m. A family is determined to start a new journey.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
The victims entered the forest at dusk. Identities of 6 of them have been confirmed: the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers Tomson Joyce, Shelley Gerald, Kelly Keith, and the project manager Russell James. The others' are still being verified.

The Weyerhaeuser used to be a leader in the wood industry, yet it went bankrupt not long ago due to the wood supply crisis these years. After donating the formula of the Resurrection Potion (basic version) to the Maria Sanatorium in New York, the Sacred Heart Sanatorium in Ohio, and the Presbyterian Church Health Center on certain conditions, the Weyerhaeusers sold all of their forestry lands.
On the night of the fire, the Weyerhaeusers, their buyers, and the workers went into the forest to start the disafforestation project before they died. The police has found traces of arcanist's activities and a small amount of gasoline at the scene, which shows the case is an arson attack. More investigations are needed to identify the suspect.

Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

Pretrial Mediation

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

An Era Remembered

小径

What an intriguing plot. Cavendish Sr. must be surprised.

Choices

1. I am surprised, too.

2. Cavendish?

Branch 1

> Did you see it too? Did you see that woman's face eroded in the dark? The ecstasy on Cavendish Jr.'s face when he turned away from the others?
>
> He was once very sensitive and very talented. He was a real f*****g genius when he made potions! But now ... He has been swallowed and digested, and yet he knew nothing about it.

Branch 2

> Oh, it's a surname buried in dust. It has been shot dead in history. Even Cavendish Jr., who was still alive and once sat in front of you, has taken off his family crown.
>
> "Forget Me Not," what a hilarious, stupid name. That young master with a pale face died, and in his place, something sinister took shape. He battled hunger and suicide countless times, but in the end, he sank into decadence.
>
> That woman gave him a promise. She said a few words to Forget Me Not, and then traveled north, and disappeared in the fog. The Windy City was an unwanted sarcoma which she left behind.
>
> Only when the gun was pointed at his throat could he see clearly what had been on his mind. Therefore, he allows himself to revenge, revenge, re-re-re-revenge, and to die.
>
> Now, the sarcoma belongs to him. He swears to build a magnificent stage there. He is patiently waiting ... to put his meanness, craziness, and quivers under the sun.

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

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Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

"Out of the Darkness and Into the Light"

小径

Now those little brats are knocked out. You noticed that old gum sticking to the bottom of their shoes, like crushed leeches.

Choices

1. What color is the gum?
2. What happened to the gum?
3. What gum? I don't care!

Branch 1

Having been chewed for long, it took on the light amber color that the carbohydrate gum should have. Some folds were cyan. It's most likely mint-flavored.

The sales champion of mint gum is the bubble gum machine near Wrigley Field. When a crazy game ends, there's always someone who needs something to chew in the mouth in order to take out the anger over the defeat.

But … Hey. Haven't you noticed yet? That wonderful mix of particles in the chewing gum base that's been squeezed into lumps?

The off-white sand. The synthetic waxed elastic fiber. In the South Bank, there is only one place where such a politically symbolic floor is laid—St. Pavlov Foundation.

Branch 2

Tragedy. A sympathetic encounter. It has fulfilled its mission cautiously and conscientiously. But clearly, no one cares.

I dare say it's the most popular mint gum now. When the Chicagoans lost their rights to get drunk, they could only turn to this nasty upstart stuff.

The sales champion is the bubble gum machine near Wrigley Field. The old gum on the kids' soles also comes from there.

Some gravel mixed into the squeezed gum base. The off-white sand. The synthetic waxed elastic fiber. In the South Bank, there is only one place where such a politically symbolic floor is laid—St. Pavlov Foundation.

Branch 3

Who does? I'm very glad that we are on the same page on this.

Describing an abandoned carbohydrate gum won't give anyone pleasure. So, let's skip to the next subject—Have you noticed the gravel mixed into the gum base?

The off-white sand. The synthetic waxed elastic fiber. In the South Bank, there is only one place where such a politically symbolic floor is laid—St. Pavlov Foundation.

It's very lively here in the square, just like every day in the past. Speculators, who advocate mankind supremacy, are trying to get the attention of the Foundation through demonstrations.

They are on the same side as the Foundation, but the Foundation has no intention to treat these protesters as allies and give them what they want. They even sent a little girl to go through the motions as a perfunctory response.

Choices

1. Little girls? An excellent topic.

Yes. Yes. No one will ever ignore them. They are honey-colored. They are the morning sun in California. They are the dazzling spot on the doe that you'll never catch.

For those hypocritical politicians, the little girls are the delicacies that they would drool over. Luckily, this little girl is not one of their prey.

She is nervous but not panicked. She doesn't seem to be good at dealing with these slick "politicians." The mission capsule of the Foundation grew hot in her tightly clutched fist.

And on the other side of the square, another little girl in a black suit is looking over here gloomily. She stood by the Foundation's air outlet, the best place for her.

The position that is too marginal to be further marginalized. That's the best portrayal of the second-generation immigrants in the 20th century.

Choices

1. Tell me about that Foundation girl.

2. Who's the girl in a black suit?

Branch 3.1

She is the good girl you already know. Orange hair. When she's deep in thought, she turns her pen like a nimble ball in a magician's hand.

She is puzzled at the guys shouting around her. But there's light in her eyes, as if she's expecting something nice.

Is it because of the next task packed in the mission capsule? Or the people she is going to meet?

Her cheeks are a little rosy now. The thing in her hands was loosened too.

Branch 3.2

She's someone you will know in the future.

Now she shudders and shivers, like a cricket desperate for shelter. She's looking for an eave or a piece of rubble in the "Storm."

Her figure might be frail, but her eyes are filled with cold anger. Maybe she had been rejected just now, or even insulted. She walked up to the square center with firm step, like a warrior.

She had to perform another task she didn't like.

At this moment, the capsule in the hand of the ad hoc representative of the Foundation dropped under the push of the crowd.

—This is a good chance.

She feels a hot wind from Africa blow towards Trapani. Then, the whole of Sicily becomes dry, warm, and comes alive. The air smells like tropical corals and wild oranges.

That wind is never supposed to be part of this cold winter. But the warm vibe lingering and dancing in her mind reminds her to live on.

She used to be desperate.

Though all she has been through was failure after failure, her vigorous vitality won't fade away, at least not now.

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
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Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

The Sacred Flame of Legend

小径

What are you doing? Why did you pick up that cold, opaque, opalescent glass wine bottle from the ground—at this most critical moment?

The scream outside the parking lot, the friction between the brake pads and the wheel drums, or the story unfolding like Giallo films. Obviously, none of them are as impressive as this bottle.

I can tell that you got good taste. You know it's not easy to get this stuff these days.

But, why are you staring at the bottom and licking your lips? Tell me, you are not going to take a sip, are you?

This is not a wise choice. You can't see the color of the liquid inside the glass. Maybe it's not the ice wine, or beer, or any homemade alcohol.

It's probably—very likely—just a critter's snot. Even so, do you still wanna give it a try?

Choices

1. Come off it. I'll take a shot.

2. I really shouldn't click this bottle.

Branch 1

Every Carbuncle you've ever met will appreciate your courage.

Now, some cold liquid runs through your throat. It trickles slowly, most likely because it's thick. But the taste is much smoother than you think.

Then, a faint scent of absinthe greeted your nostril, and maltose, and lemon thyme, and coconut sugar. It's as delicious as a present from the arcanist from New Zealand.

And at the same time, your heart swells, and you feel a scorching energy fill your windpipe.

Your vision begins to blur. You kinda see the rough letter on the bottom: The Walden Potion Bar.

Choices

1. What the F**k is this?

It's anything but alcohol! "Alcohol" is a taboo. But it will empower you to face the next damn reality.

Choices

1. Who are you?

Me? Ha, I am no one.

But I can also be anyone—a drunken, slovenly old man, a cleaner in a run-down hotel, a fund manager greedy for more, or a cute spinning crystal skull.

Now I'm a drunkard with good taste, just like you.

And the day when we formally meet each other is coming soon.

Now, lift your big ass and continue your wonderful journey. I will appear at any time, any moment, no matter you expect or not.

Branch 2

Right. It only took one moment for you to decide to click, while you had to stand so much nonsense for no reason.

My apologies if the story didn't unfold as you expected. But luckily, you still have your sanity that you are always proud of.

Come here. Let's put down the bottle. Before Sonetto and that floating APPLe notice your unusual behavior, you still have a chance to restore your image.

After me, say "Hi" to them. Pretend you've never been tempted by the bottle.

Choices

1. "Hi."

2. Are you sure they can hear it?

Branch 2.1

Oh. Hi! How are you doing?

Hahahahaha. Excellent. Now we all know how effective the training of the Foundation is. Good news: everyone likes good kids.

It's so nice talking to you. You're better than your ... Oops, I should stop here.

Choices

1. Who the hell are you?

Me? Ha, I am no one.

But I can also be anyone—a drunken, slovenly old man, a cleaner in a run-down hotel, a fund manager greedy for more, or a cute spinning crystal skull.

Now I am a nice and friendly adventurer, just like you.

Don't worry. The day when we formally meet each other is coming soon.

Now, lift your big ass and continue your wonderful journey. I will appear at any time, any moment, no matter you expect or not.

Branch 2.2

...

I really wanna find out what you're composed of! I'll chew and swallow all the gene analysis down to my stomach, so I can figure out ... how did you keep your sanity!

No arcanist is ever as rational and restrained as you. They should, they should ... If there is really one in the world, that should be ...

And I know so much about you. Too much about you! Even I cannot deny what you are. I can't!

Choices

1. Who the hell are you?

Me? Ha, I am no one.

But I can also be anyone—a drunken, slovenly old man, a cleaner in a run-down hotel, a fund manager greedy for more, or a cute spinning crystal skull.

But now I'm only a rubber asshole whose mischief just failed. A desperate loser. My wrath can't even burn a weed in the Pacific Ocean.

I'm looking forward to the day we formally meet each other. Only then ...

Now, lift your big ass and continue your wonderful journey. I will appear at any time, any moment, no matter you expect or not!

Shared continuation

Shared continuation

Excerpt from the New York Times

Around midnight two days ago, a large fire broke out in the oak forest on the western outskirts. The delay of the warning and the complex terrains full of inflammables in the forest resulted in a fire that lasted a whole night till dawn and 13 deaths.
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Reporter: James Welles/Dorey Johnson

A Box of Fake Tickets

小径

A Box of Fake Tickets

> Counterfeit Ticket Seizure Information
> January 17th, 1991
>
> Eucalyptus Brotherhood: 65 Tickets Seized
>
> January 19th, 1991
>
> Slicky: 80 Tickets Seized
>
> Slicky was also remarkably unprofessional in this instance. Did they really think that printing "Employee Ticket" directly on the front of their counterfeits would make people think they were actually real? Moreover, the workmanship is of laughable quality.
>
> January 21st, 1991
>
> Little Scissors Jerry: 240 Tickets Seized
>
> An increasing number of fake tickets are floating around on the market, and all I can do is try my best to confiscate as many of them as I can to prevent them from making their way into the hands of unsuspecting spectators.
>
> The gangs have already put a target on my back. I need to make sure I draw less attention to myself next time.

The Lovely Neighbor

RUG-02

Laplace reception room

Vertin: Now, let's summarize what happened.

Vertin: You fell into a coma for 16 minutes and 30 seconds yesterday due to external impact. Then you woke up and found yourself fine.

Spathodea: That's right.

Vertin: On that night, you felt an "unusual burn" coming up to your throat from your stomach. At the same time, you had weird illusions ...

Vertin: ... And at last, you vomited, a ball of fire.

Spathodea: Yes, that's right, exactly!

Vertin: For one last time ...

Vertin: Are you sure no one in your family is related to the Red Dragon?

Spathodea: One hundred percent positive! I checked all the family photos and medical records, and even rang Mom and Dad! They denied every possibility of it!

Choices

1. Ugh ...

Vertin: This symptom is really rare to see.

Spathodea: I know! So, don't walk away on me!

Each of her hands clenches one wrist from the other two, joining them together like a floating buoy line in a swimming pool.

Desert Flannel: Are you really buying that?

Vertin: I don't doubt it.

Desert Flannel: Then you're a f**king doughnut. Would have lost all your clothes to any rorter that comes up to you if you wandered long enough on the streets.

Desert Flannel: And you—I'm warning you—take your little claws off me! Let me go NOW!

Spathodea: Hey! You were the one who burst out of nowhere and knocked me over! Now my brain is not working right, and you are responsible for it!

Desert Flannel: Yeah? You mean this smidge of zombie fire? You reckon this is the first time an arcanist sees it? Can get you twenty of these in two days in any workshop! You gotta try harder if you wanna fool me!

Spathodea: Whoa whoa whoa?! I'm not a liar! I saw that ball of fire come out of my mouth!

Irritated by their skepticism, she shoves the fire into her mouth.

Spathodea: Hee? It, doen't, vurn ee, at all! I am o a iar! (See? It doesn't burn me at all! I am not a liar!)

Desert Flannel: You frauds never stop coming up with new scams. "No cheat, no eat," heard that before?

Desert Flannel: Go home with your fake fire. If you continue doing this, be careful of the Bunyips! They will crawl into your house through the sewage and take your tongue, because lies are their favorite food!

Vertin: But there is no evidence to prove that she's telling a lie.

Desert Flannel: Evidence? I have more than enough evidence to prove she's not some innocent lamb!

Desert Flannel: She climbed up the tree outside my window and was shouting and screaming there in the middle of the night. The moment I went outside, she took me here like she was carrying a bag of groceries.

Vertin: ... One may infer that she was shocked by the fire-vomiting and thus ... displayed abnormal behaviors.

Desert Flannel: My God! Don't you have adults at home to put some senses in your head?!
Haven't they taught you not to trust the strangers' words, especially if they show up at late hours?!

Spathodea: S-Stranger?!

Spathodea: I know something's wrong with my head, and I'm not even sure who I really am anymore, but you shouldn't have forgotten me!

Spathodea: We're neighbors, Desert Flannel! I live three streets away. I even said hello to you!

Desert Flannel: Three streets away? How does it make us "neighbors"?

Desert Flannel: And I don't think our litter-covered street is a part of your fancy community, where people sit by the white fountains and walk in the street gardens. The last time I checked, I was not from some rich immigrant family.

Desert Flannel: No matter what you're looking for, for money or for fun, I couldn't care less about it. The only thing I care about is my landlord will kick me out if I fail to pay my rent this month! So, let, me, go!

Desert Flannel struggles, pulls her arm out of the grip, and storms off.

Spathodea: No! You must not leave!

Spathodea jumps up from the sofa and grabs Desert Flannel's collar roll, but loses her balance.

Like toppling dominoes, the three of them fall over each other and tumble down on the ground.

Vertin: ... Uh ...

Desert Flannel: Ah! Hiss ... I think I just nicked you in the teeth ...

Spathodea: You must not leave! At least not before I figure out what happened to me!

Spathodea: Things are flashing in my mind now! Sometimes the past, sometimes the present. I remember I can sing, but soon I forget how to do that.

Spathodea: I remember the crowd who worshiped me on their knees, the run in somewhere like the Uluru Stadium, and something hot ... a hot bonfire? Is that a bonfire?

Spathodea: Anyway! No matter what it is, I'm just an ordinary person like anyone else living at the end of the century! These things shouldn't be in my mind!

Spathodea: There must be something wrong with me! With my head, or other parts!

Spathodea: I can't just go nuts now! My training plan, it's-it's all ruined. *sobs* I even have a game to play at the end of the year.

Vertin: Relax, the symptoms may not last. Sensing "omens" doesn't always mean danger to arcanists.

Vertin: Given the complexity of the situation, I think you need a more detailed physical examination to find the crux.

Vertin: We will help you and take care of you ...

Vertin: Until you completely recover, or say, become completely normal again.

Spathodea: You ... *sobs* Thank goodness, at least I can count on you!

Spathodea: Both my mom and dad aren't home right now. I'm on my own. It's all over for me if the condition gets worse—at least that's how it goes on the TV.

Vertin: Don't jump to the worst conclusion yet. Follow me.

Spathodea: Okay. Thank you.

Spathodea wipes off the tears in her eyes and keeps up with Vertin. But soon they both stop and turn back to the one still on the sofa.

Desert Flannel: ...

Desert Flannel: What? What are you staring at?

Desert Flannel: She's having a body check-up. Do I have to tag along?

Spathodea: You are going to sneak away for those "part-time jobs," aren't you?!

Desert Flannel: Fine, genius. You win.

Murmuring something, Desert Flannel unwillingly follows the team.

Desert Flannel: Oi, you with the suitcase. Do you know how I can get a job here? Looks like they pay their employees well.

5#1

The Torch Guardians I

小径

An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

Chinga! Chinga!

RUG-03

Laplace clinic

Medical Staff: Here is Ms. Spathodea's physical examination.

Medicine Pocket: Oh, how sweet. They even got you the Salvia Zopiclone patches.

Medicine Pocket: If the "illusions" get too real and you can't sleep, use them.

Spathodea: Okay, thanks.
But I need to ask my coach if I can use it.

Medicine Pocket: Don't worry. It's been approved by the Therapeutic Goods Administration of Campbell. The ingredients include salvia, mint, and a hallucination potion. They can neutralize the side effect perfectly.

The researcher opens the girl's medical record, takes off the patch sticking to the cover, and slides it to the girl.

Medicine Pocket: Actually, you are quite the lucky one, you know.

Medicine Pocket: That old map shows there used to be stairs where you fell down, with over 100 steps. Thank goodness you live in the right time; otherwise, you would have tumbled all the way down there.

Medicine Pocket: In that case, no one can tell what you would vomit, fire, or maybe something even worse. Hmm?

Medicine Pocket's voice dies down like a flame being blown out.

Muted for a while, Medicine Pocket briskly collects the files on the table and walks towards the door.

Medicine Pocket: Wait here. I need to get someone.

Medicine Pocket: A weirdo for sure, yet the best person we can turn to for this problem.

Spathodea: ...?

Desert Flannel: Aaaaalright. I think that's the last thing I'd like to hear from a doctor.

Desert Flannel: Would you just let go of my hand, sheila? Or the good doctor here will have to cut this hand off later because of necrosis.

Spathodea: I-I will! But can I hold it for another five minutes, please? I'm sort of nervous.

Time spent in anxiety feels like a year.

Spathodea: *deep breath*

Desert Flannel: That's right, breathe in, breathe out. Then unbend the fingers. I'm also human, I feel pain too, sweetheart.

The footsteps of the mysterious guest coming from the hallway are getting closer and closer.

???: I can't believe how lucky I am. We haven't seen a living case for decades!

???: This is exciting. Thank you for letting me know about this, Medicine Pocket.

Medicine Pocket: Not at all, Ezra, my dear friend. See, I always keep you and your weird little mushrooms at the back of my mind, so it'd be best if you could give them to me without leaving any records in Laplace's system next time.

Medicine Pocket: Anyway, we can talk about that later. Now, go check out the girl. She might be very useful for your paper on arcanum.

Ezra: Of course, I'll tend to her in a moment. I just want to tell you how much I appreciate your thoughtfulness. I've been waiting for this for too long.

Ezra turns directly to Spathodea.

Spathodea: What?

The young researcher walks to her, as steady as a boat floating on the water, smiling.

Spathodea: Me? You mean, me?

Ezra: Certainly, Ms. Spathodea. I came for you.

Ezra: I've been briefed on your case and had a basic understanding of the inner flame temperature and the fuel through the laboratory report. Here is a list summarizing all the conditions. It's still a draft, but please take a look.

She sees a list with dense writing in ink that has barely dried.

Ezra: Since your condition has stabilized and, as a teenager, you're still in a developmental stage, I'd recommend you to run a test which is more friendly and pleasant to your nose.

Ezra grabs a Y-shaped metal rod and a piece of cotton-like material and holds them in his palm.

Ezra: Now, please blink three times at this dowsing rod and blow on it as lightly as possible.

Spathodea: Wh-What's this?

Ezra: Oooh, no, not like that. Just be gentle with it. Lower your voice so that you don't blow away the spores on the filter.

The white filter paper almost touches the tip of her nose. She can't say no to such a gentle and soft request like that.

So she closes her eyes, lowers and lowers her voice, and repeats the instruction to herself.

Spathodea: O-Okay.
Blink three times ... and blow ... phew ...

The fluorescent spores on the filter paper curl immediately and turn a cheery ember color.

Ezra: And we're going to roll it up and fix it on the dowsing rod. Now, time will do its magic.

Spathodea: Doctor, is there a cure for my head? Wait, is that the smell of mushroom?

Ezra: It is related to mushrooms, and I'm not a doctor.

Ezra: Please forgive me, Ms. Spathodea. I was so overjoyed. I forgot to introduce myself.

Ezra: Hello, I'm Ezra.

Ezra: I'm a human researcher at Laplace Australia Branch. My research is mostly on the diversity of local mushrooms and fungi. I'm very thrilled to meet you.

Spathodea: You are not a doctor? Just a researcher and a human?

Spathodea: And you are working on mushrooms?

Ezra: That's right. It's a shame that I didn't become a member of the Arcane Study team, but I'm equally interested in mushrooms. I enjoy this job.

Spathodea turns pale holding her face, and steps back in horrified disbelief.

Spathodea: So, they get you here to treat me, which means ...

Spathodea: I am not a descendant of the Red Dragon, but that of mushrooms? I-I'm a fire-breathing mushroom girl?!

Ezra: No, I'm not here to diagnose your abnormality, Ms. Spathodea.

Ezra: You're perfectly healthy. Your brain CT result looks normal, and I can see you're in good shape. In a stricter medical sense, you're almost one of the healthiest people I've ever seen.

Desert Flannel: Ha! Finally, someone has a sharp eye!

Desert Flannel: So the truth has been unraveled—there has never been any illusions, nor is anybody putting on some strange, absurd fire-spitting show, and ...

Ezra: But she did not lie. Please take a look at this.

Ezra: According to the analysis, the core of her fire consists of an obsidian gravel that has 22 evenly distributed layers.

Ezra: This is no modern thing. It's old, dating back thousands of years.

Desert Flannel: What ... what do you mean? Whose side you're on?

Ezra: Emm. Have I made it difficult for you to understand?

Ezra: Well, you'll know when you see it. Please bear with me for five minutes.

Holding the metal rod, Ezra switches the buttons on the machine. The moss in the backpack exhales, letting out a cloud of mist.

Ezra: Have you heard of the "reincarnators"?

Ezra unfolds the filter paper and holds the two ends of the rod.

Ezra: It's one of the arcanist's lineages, a rare kind. Since this power can only be randomly triggered, and its manifestation could happen anywhere, anytime, and in any fashion, it is hard to identify them when there is one.

Ezra: The most well-known case must be Dorothy of London.

Ezra: She fell down the stairs in her own house and lost every vital sign. But she woke again and became the ancient Egyptian Bentreshyt.

Desert Flannel: You ... you are not saying that she's ...

Ezra: Ms. Spathodea is a "reincarnator."

Ezra: Those so-called illusions are not the result of any brain damage, they were once real. It's her past.

Ezra: Based on the past cases, she'll go through a period of mental turmoil. That could be short or longer than anyone could expect, but eventually, she will become herself again—the old self.

Desert Flannel: But how is that possible? Everybody knows that the "reincarnators" are just some lousy, made-up tabloid stories.

Ezra: That's right. Sensationalism—that's the mainstream opinion about the "reincarnators."

Ezra: In Dorothy's case, her experience of learning Egyptian and her career as an archaeologist also caused controversies over her true lineage, which is understandable since people haven't seen any "reincarnator" in years.

Ezra: But at the beginning of the 20th century, when Dorothy fell down the stairs which decided her fate, Laplace Scientific Computing Center established its Australia Branch, carrying out studies of local fungi.

Ezra: The fungi study is a brand new direction, and it has been secretly developing next to the public since, like the Australian honey fungus, growing without getting anyone's attention.

Ezra: The facts will speak for themselves. Please allow me to prove it to you.

Ezra: Medicine Pocket, could you please turn off the light for us?

Ezra: Cheers.

The poles of that metal fork sway in the dark room, letting out a buzzing sound like a bee floating in the air.

Ezra: When we talk about reincarnation, the real question behind it is whether the "soul" exists.

Ezra: Because the "soul" is commonly considered to be the essence of what makes a person who he or she is. If a person dies, his or her soul will return to the ever-circulating network.

Spathodea: Network? What network?

Ezra: A theory developed from Riemann's On the Hypotheses Which Underlie Geometry described the world as an eternal, vast, invisible, yet ubiquitous net.

Vertin: And as the news story described, a "reincarnator" is a miracle where a "soul" disappears from point A and shows up at point B without any clear reasons.

Ezra: Exactly, Ms. Vertin! I'm amazed that you know so much about the "reincarnators"!

The sparkling spores, floating in the humid air, slowly approach each other and intertwine.

Ezra: That report described the "reincarnators" is incomprehensible and spontaneous, but the truth is, we have never gotten close enough to observe and study them.

Spathodea: Mmm. Hmm? What's this shiny powder on my fingers?

Spathodea looks upwards and can't help from letting out a small cry.

Spathodea: Gosh, it's like the neural network I read in the textbook!

Ezra: You have a sharp sense. You arcanists never cease to amaze me! The latest studies have shown that the working mechanism of mushroom flora may be similar to the brain's, and we have made some progress from that.

Ezra: This is why the study of mushrooms is important; it enriches our understanding of the "reincarnators," for they are hard to find.

Spathodea: You mean, these things floating in the air are mushrooms?

Ezra: The Australian honey fungus, the mushrooms living beneath the ground.

Ezra: It's a pathogenic gem that causes the roots to rot. It was first discovered in a Eucalyptus plantation in southeastern Australia.

Ezra: At the end of the 1970s, Laplace researchers who intervened in the local environment protection found that, unlike other fungi which reproduce through the spreading of spores, the honey fungi spread by the growth of their underground mycelia all over the forest.

Vertin: You think it's like that "invisible net"?

Ezra: Yes. A net hiding underground, in which you see an object disappear at point A and magically emerge again at point B. The "reincarnators" are very similar to Australian honey fungus in this aspect.

Ezra: And with her breath, a small amount of her saliva, and the dowsing rod, we will be able to find her net and map her movements on it.

Ezra: And when her gaze emblazes the Omphalotus nidiformis ...

Desert Flannel: Ompha ... Omphalotus what? Isn't that the ghost fungus?

Ezra: Yes, the ghost fungus. The mushrooms that glow in the dark.

Ezra: They're called Chinga in older times, which means spirit and soul, the sparkle of ideas in human minds.

Vertin: If the mushroom has simulated Spathodea's "net," then these two light spots are ...

Ezra: The one closer to us represents the current Ms. Spathodea, and the farther and brighter one is what put her through the changes now.

Spathodea: So, that's me in the past?

Spathodea: And I-I will gradually turn into her?

The light is back in the room. The ventilator emitting two consecutive notifications as it extracts the sparkling lights out together with the heavy moisture in the air.

Ezra: Five minutes, we are right on time.

Ezra: Ms. Desert Flannel, how do you feel ...

Desert Flannel: D**n it! If she's so badly injured, how much would the compensation be? Is this how my life will be? Being heavily in debt?

Ezra: Ms. Desert Flannel, you're nibbling at your nails. You will get hurt from it, please stop.

Desert Flannel: Me? I'm fine. You ... are you talking to me? You were saying ...?

Ezra: Yes. I was asking how you are doing. Did you get my drift?

Desert Flannel: I ... I think ...

Desert Flannel: Well, I know it's highly unlikely that this little girl was hatched from a dragon's egg, but is it possible that she's just some kind of uncommon lizard? You know, the really ancient ones? Any, anything but a "reincarnator"!

Ezra: But ... but what you said doesn't make sense ...

Desert Flannel: What do you mean "it doesn't make sense"? There was fire coming out of her mouth!

Desert Flannel points at the fire "placed" on the couch, which is still burning, and shakes her digital pet machine.

Desert Flannel: And my only family here is a pixel emu. Does it make sense to you?

Ezra: I don't follow ...

Ezra: I know this is not your fault. It's just your arcanist nature taking over. It's very normal if you got too carried away by your emotions and became delusional and hysterical.

Ezra: Please take my hand. I was once trained to help arcanists calm down. Now breathe with me, in ... and out ...

Desert Flannel: Me? I'm not hysterical!

Said the hysterical girl with offense.

Spathodea: Hey, what do you know about arcanists? You're not even one of us!

Said the outraged bystander.

In the white room, the argument snowballs tumbling out of control, letting a wisp of smoke slither across the room unnoticed.

Vertin: Everyone ...

Ezra: Please believe me that I meant you no harm, Ms. Spathodea. I was only trying to help.

Spathodea: Help? How? By calling us delusional?

Spathodea: There is nothing I hate more than humans like you saying that others are "over-emotional"!

Vertin: People.

Ezra: No, nothing like that. Ms. Spathodea. It is not my intention to criticize anything or anyone. It's just, biologically, arcanists tend to be more sensitive and easily affected.

Ezra: I also like arcanists, almost as much as I'm interested in mushrooms, that's why I study them ... Hmm?

Ezra: Do you smell something burning?

Before they realize it, the flame "placed" on the couch has already devoured its seat and the floor, spread to the door, and completely blocked their way out. The burning heat is approaching at a terrifying speed.

Spathodea: A fire?! It's the flame I spat out! Wh-When did it grow so large!?

Vertin: I tried to warn you.

Vertin: It has grown larger and larger as your "lizard hypothesis" heated up. I'm sure the guards of Laplace will break in soon.

Laplace Security: Security of Laplace Research Center Hospital taking over. All patients and non-staff, please follow me to evacuate the room!

Laplace Security: Evaluating fire level ... Level 2. Extinguishing the fire.

Laplace Security: Source of ignition confirmed. Request for permission to use Kangaroo Foam Fire Extinguisher III!

Spathodea: Whoa! Wait wait wait! You can't put out my flame!

Spathodea: It's important for me, very, very important! I don't know why, but its importance is for sure! Those bubble kangaroos will kick its butt once they see the flames! I don't want that!

Vertin: I'll protect it for you. Don't worry.

Medical Staff: There you go. Now you're free from the fuzzy foam.

Spathodea: Thank goodness, uh, I mean thank you. Though I still smell like a joey, I'm much better now.

Medical Staff: In the early stages of arcane ability awakening, the rate of arcanists losing control can reach 74.3%.

Medical Staff: But it doesn't mean that you can set a fire in the clinic of the Laplace Research Center Hospital, or fight the security to "protect the flame."

Spathodea: *sobs* I know. I'm sorry. I didn't mean to do this, and I have no idea why my flame grew so ... so large all of a sudden. That never happened before.

Spathodea: I know I should have been responsible and noticed the anomaly earlier. I-I was completely lost in the argument.

She buries her face in her hands and is still trying to bury it even deeper.

Medical Staff: The silver lining is, as the fire was still under control, they used the Kangaroo Foam Fire Extinguisher, and thus it didn't cause any casualties.

Medical Staff: Please write down your emotional changes and physical reactions that occurred during the incident on this sheet of paper. We'll keep tracking your physical health information.

Medical Staff: The Concentration Potion is on that table, and there are blankets and Type II PMMA safety boxes in the cabinet under the table. Please keep the hazards sealed for safekeeping.

Spathodea: Okay. Got it.

Medical Staff: You are still in an unstable state. Please have a rest here, and don't move around.

Medical Staff: If you need anything, please press the call bell on your left, and our nursing staff will come to help.

The medical staff collects the tray and walks out of the clinic, leaving the room in silence again.

Spathodea: Hmm. Well, in case we burn another room ...

Spathodea: The box she mentioned is ... Oh, here it is.

Flame: *burning*

She opens the transparent box and leans in towards the little flame.

Spathodea: I know freedom matters, little flame.

Spathodea: But we have no choice. Sorry, buddy!

Flame: *burning*

She reaches out a hand to push the flame into the box with great caution.

Spathodea: All right, listen, my teacher said fire needs oxygen to burn, so I'll leave a small window for you to breathe.

Flame: I ... have ... always ... wanted ...

Flame: to ... see ... you ...

Spathodea: What?!

Flame: Go ...

Spathodea: Are-Are you talking?! Gosh! The call bell! Where's the call bell?

Flame: Go ... back ... to ... Ulu ...

Flame: We must ... go back to ... Uluru ... Games ...

Spathodea: ...!

Spathodea: Uluru ... Uluru Games? You mean, the Uluru Games?

Spathodea: Make it clear, little flame, make it clear! What's going on with the Uluru Games?

Spathodea grabs the flame in a hurry.

The sparkling flame starts devouring her palm bite by bite.

Spathodea: Ah! The fire ... It's burning on me?! It feels different this time. It's so hot ...

Far faster than expected, the flame spreads over her, and her cry for help fades into the burning red.

5#1

Cross · 1/2

RUG-04

Lakeside Garden

Desert Flannel: Is this the Laplace fashion of dealing with emergencies?

Desert Flannel: I swear, if anyone walks past us now, schoolers or derros, I will be instantly killed by their silent judgment.

Ezra: As a matter of fact, when the patient or the subject becomes unstable during contact, it is necessary to isolate them from the triggering cause immediately.

Ezra: But, we just burnt down the isolation room.

Ezra: No wonder Head Nurse Judith was so angry.

Kangaroo: URAGH!

Vertin: ...

Ezra: Ms. Vertin, are you alright?

Ezra: That kangaroo is ... punching your nose.

Vertin: I'm fine.

Kangaroo: URAGH!

Vertin: So is the kangaroo.

Vertin: I'm sure Medicine Pocket will bring us the Concentration Potion soon.

Desert Flannel: They'd better. We look like a bunch of kangaroos, feel like kangaroos, and even smell like kangaroos!

Desert Flannel: We will make tomorrow's headline of Australian Nagger and become "the three kangaroos hanging out on a public lawn at midnight." That'd be the end of our social lives as humans and the beginning of a life as kangaroos.

Ezra: Make the headline? Aah, I see. Please don't worry.

Ezra: Although it's true that Medicine Pocket is a frequent celebrity on the news, the Concentration Potion is not their work. Besides, we didn't use anything new in its development ...

Desert Flannel: I'm not worried about that guy. I was talking about myself. There are paparazzi following me around these days.

Vertin: I didn't know you were famous.

Desert Flannel: I'm not. It's just that someone wants my name spread in a bad way. Trust me, you should never piss off the paparazzi.

Ezra: You should turn to the police for help.

Desert Flannel: Yeah yeah, just shut up and keep your eyes peeled for anything suspicious.

Desert Flannel: I will toss his shoes on the power lines, if I found him here.

Ezra: Ms. Desert Flannel, watch your back!

Desert Flannel: What, are those paparaz- ... Aaah, waaaah! It burns!

The young girl leaps to her feet, letting out a scream as the bench beneath her turned scorching hot.

Ezra: Is this ... fire? Ms. Desert Flannel, the lake is over there! Get in there!

Desert Flannel: Lake? I ... I can't swim!

Kangaroo: URAAGH!AHHH!!

There are people shouting, feet running, sparks flying.

Desert Flannel: Aaah! This stupid kangaroo kicked me in the eye, ouch! Move, move! I can't see where the lake is!

Vertin: Wait, calm down!

Vertin: You are not in danger. She is.

Desert Flannel: Are you joking?! I was getting burned. Emm? There's nothing on my skin.

The unwanted visitor stands in front of them, panting as if she's burning from her body temperature.

Her golden reflection sways in water like real flames.

Spathodea: *deep breath*

Spathodea: Race.

The burning flame bounces from Desert Flannel to Ezra.

Ezra: ... Uh ...

Ezra: It didn't cause any damage on me, just burning the foam on my skin. Is that some new method developed to get rid of the potion?

Ezra: But what is Ms. Spathodea doing here? The head nurse shouldn't have let an unstable patient walk around freely. Did, did she sneak out?!

Desert Flannel: Gosh! Mate, she's on fire! Does she even remotely look stable to you?

Spathodea: Race, like a deor ... stepping on the red soil where vines and woods grow ...

The glare and heat rush through her, like waves.

Spathodea, engulfed in flame, approaches Desert Flannel, with fiery eyes, mouth, heart, and body, and takes her into her arms.

Desert Flannel: Urrah!

Desert Flannel: Aah, f**k me dead! She's as well heated as a boiling pot! We can't let her go on like this! Her brain is going to be roasted in that little head!

Desert Flannel strives to get out of her control, patting Spathodea on the cheeks with her cold hands.

Desert Flannel: Let go, Spathodea! Your temperature is dangerously high. Chill out!

Spathodea: I'm not ... a lizard ... and ...

Spathodea: Concrete No. 2 with cream is the best dish and pipe material!

Vertin: Spathodea is suffering confusion. It's probably the flame's doing.

Vertin: We need to separate them first.

Ezra: Okay ... okay! Ms. Vertin, please step back!

A mist with the color of turquoise blows toward the girls.

Desert Flannel: Oi! What are you sprayin- ...?! I'm still here! Hey!

Soon, both Desert Flannel's complaints and Spathodea's sleep talk quiet down.

Ezra: This is just some spores, Ms. Desert Flannel, worry not.

Ezra: They are the tranquilizer that the locals used to pacify animals and was once widely used among arcanists in early times for hunting.

Ezra: As long as we calm her down, we can bring her back to ... Whooaa!

However, that fireball girl hits everyone in front of her like knocking down all the pins in a row.

A perfect bowling strike.

Spathodea: Games ... Games! Games! We need the real Games!

Spathodea: This is where sportsmanship originates ... Young people, young ... people ...

Spathodea: Young people need cats! And strawberry ja- ... jam! Cat jam it is!

Ezra: Did I use the wrong mushroom? Ms. Spathodea has become even more restless!

Ezra: What about Ms. Desert Flannel? Is she ...

Ezra manages to get up, looking at the turquoise green mist without dusting himself off.

Vertin: No, you didn't. She's behaving exactly the way you described.

Ezra: Aah ... Ms. ... Desert Flannel?

Desert Flannel: ... Heh-heh.

Their fierce friend, with a smile on her face, is rolling on the ground like a cat getting high on catmints.

She keeps reaching her hands to the sky as if she is trying to catch something.

Desert Flannel: Is this ... the house for me? Heh heh, oh ... Haha ...

Desert Flannel: Does this mean I don't have to ... pay rent anymore? Heh heh ...

Vertin: Looks like this is how she has her mental break.

Ezra: I will bring her back to normal immediately. It won't take mo-more than five minutes. But I think Ms. Spathodea is going to attack again!

Spathodea: What ye need is the reopening of the gate to the scorching land, and ...

Spathodea: And ... the retrieval of the rock ... Ugh ...

Ezra: And her fire is getting stronger ... Get down!

The moment they duck, the scorching hot fire flies over the top of their heads.

Vertin: We are running out of time. Let's deal with the burning issue first.

Taking a deep breath, Ezra grabs the straps even tighter.

Ezra: I will! I will try my best!

The Torch Guardians II

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An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
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>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

Cross · 2/2

RUG-04

Spathodea: Ugh, where am I?

Spathodea: What are you doing here, guys? I thought you were driven away?

Ezra: Great, she's back to normal!

Spathodea: Oh ... I remember it now ...

Spathodea can't maintain her balance and falls to the ground.

Vertin: Spathodea!

Spathodea: The Games ...

She raises one arm with all her strength and grasps the cuff of the girl standing in front of her.

Spathodea: We must revive ... the Uluru Games ...

Spathodea: Because ... the rocks, rumble on the knees ...

Medical Staff: I've heard what's going on.

Medical Staff: We will check if her organs are injured by the high temperature after returning to Laplace. You can visit her tomorrow after 11:00 a.m.

Ezra: Emm? Can we visit her? I thought you would send her to the wards on the 13th floor.

Medical Staff: Go with the flow when you can't fight it.

Medical Staff: We've now understood what will happen if we separate you and keep her alone some place else. What's more, Laplace can't lose another clinic.

Ezra: I see, this is great! Thank you!

The white ambulance drives away from the street.

Desert Flannel: So, are you sure those mushrooms won't cause any damage to my brain and body?

Desert Flannel: Like lower IQ levels, lung diseases, or skin allergy ...

Ezra: Emm. If you think it's necessary, I will accompany you to Laplace for some follow-up check-ups!

Ezra: Of course, you don't have to pay for the tests. The fee will be deducted from my salary. Please don't worry about the money.

Desert Flannel: Okay okay! Enough! I trust you! I don't need a kid to pay the doctor for me. Besides ...

Desert Flannel: It's embarrassing enough to be put down by mushrooms, not to mention that I'll be giving that guy the story they carved if I was hospitalized.

Ezra: "That guy"? Ah, you mean, the journalist following you.

Ezra: Emm ...

Desert Flannel: Was that a flash?! Speak of the devil ... B****r!

Silently cursing, Desert Flannel scans the bush in the dark with a serious look on her face.

Desert Flannel: Come out yourself. Don't make me force you!

The bush rustles. Seconds later, a man stands up. His black shirt indistinguishable from the darkness, making his face appear as if it were floating in the air.

???: Heh.

Desert Flannel: Makower, don't you dare involve others. This is between you and me.

Makower: I've told you long ago that one day I will make you feel the same misery that I did. I've been following you all the time, and this is the moment, the moment of vengeance!

Makower: Heh-heh, now, I have more than enough photos.

Makower: As for these "other people" ... You didn't strike me as such a kind-hearted person.

Desert Flannel: I didn't know you are so shameless!

Makower: Let's see what tomorrow's newspaper has to say about this, Ms. Photographer.

A hideous smile forms on that floating face. Makower then disappears in the shadow.

Desert Flannel: No, we can't let him get away. He has a photo of us!

Ezra: Is he your enemy ... emm, maybe archenemy? What happened between you two?

Desert Flannel: If you don't wanna be one of the "burning kangaroos" on the headline tomorrow, shut up and start running!

Vertin: We have to stop him.

5#1

The Buoy Balls · 1/2

RUG-05

???: ...

Collar raised and head lowered, standing silently by the side door of the newsstand.

???: G'day, you got the latest Australian Nagger here?

Newsstand Owner: Nice choice. Everyone is talking about ... Hmm?

The strange customer snatches the paper from the newsstand owner and lapses into reading.

???: "A strange party held in the City Park last night ..."

???: "... The witness claimed to see the burning kangaroos, mushroom-intoxicated rolling croc, and the teenage arsonist dancing together ... A secret event on the public lawn ... The revival of the Uluru Games ..."

Fingers clutching at the newspaper tremble. The newspaper wrinkles, breaks ...

???: "It saddens us to admit that the recession and inflation have walloped some young adults ... They were ... crawling in the park at night ..."

???: "Groaning and moaning like beasts, dragging themselves along, and losing consciousness ..."

The voice, the figure, the temper, and the reaction all seem familiar.

Newsstand Owner: Wait, your voice ... Are you ...

Desert Flannel: Do you have to talk to me right now?

Behind the rustling newspaper is a familiar face with frowning eyebrows and bloodshot eyes.

Desert Flannel: I'm busy hating my life. I don't have time for your little chit-chat.

Newsstand Owner: No way, Desert Flannel. It's really you!

Newsstand Owner: Everybody is talking about you right now! And they can really imagine. Some say you're mad, some say you're the hero fighting against aliens ...

Newsstand Owner: Well, the most known story is "that event." Is it real that you're going to restart the Games?

Desert Flannel: I have nothing to do with it! It was all that junior's fault. I was just unlucky!

Fold, and open, and fold, and open.

Desert Flannel leafs through the newspaper, pacing back and forth like an animal trapped in the cage of the zoo.

Desert Flannel: It was pure bad luck that I ran into those weirdos, got taken to the hospital, and let Makower get what he wants.

Desert Flannel: I shouldn't have let him get away. If I see him again, I swear, I will pull out his tongue and tie it around his neck!

Desert Flannel: Look at this gibberish. He said we are the d**eheads who eat Bunyips from the sewage, a burning kangaroo, and I am a nutter because I can't find a way to afford rent!

Desert Flannel: This is great. I might as well be a kangaroo!

Newsstand Owner: At least it's true that you're banging your head against the wall for rent.

Desert Flannel: ...

Desert Flannel: Yeah, be mindful that you're talking to a nutter.

Glared at by those sharp eyes, the newsstand owner withdraws behind the counter and puts his hands on his knees like a good boy.

Desert Flannel: Ha, whatever. I will soon lose my part-time jobs and be kicked out of the house where my granny lived for decades.

The crumpled newspaper is thrown into the newsstand and Desert Flannel puts her hands back in her pockets.

Desert Flannel: I'm heading back. Let me know if you know any job vacancies. I can do a lot of things, as long as the money is good ... no, as long as I'm paid.

Newsstand Owner: Wait, Desert Flannel. Come and take a look at this.

A delicate wooden box is placed on the crumpled newspaper, with a lot of tickets inside.

Newsstand Owner: So many people came here this morning, asking about the Uluru Games. And one hour before, the Scissors Jerry brought me this.

Desert Flannel: This is ... a pre-sale ticket to the Uluru Games?

Newsstand Owner: I've sold over 50 tickets, at a unit price of ... this much.

Looking around to make sure that there is nobody nearby, the owner makes a gesture. Desert Flannel's jaw drops.

Desert Flannel: Huh?

She lowers her gaze to the newspaper. In a lively font, the headline reads: "Uluru Games."

Newsstand Owner: It has been suspended for too long, so long that everyone thinks society has forgotten it.

Newsstand Owner: But we remember—our ancestors told us about those amazing and funny sports, that big, wide, and fancy Stadium.

Desert Flannel: They all remember it, even looking forward to it, and even bid up for a fake ticket. Mate, did you get more of these from the other gangs?

Newsstand Owner: Two boxes left.

Holding the cigarette between the knuckles of his index and middle fingers, the owner squats down behind the counter.

His hands lift up, holding two even bigger and heavier boxes. His voice comes from below.

Newsstand Owner: These are from the Slicky and Eucalyptus Brotherhood.

Desert Flannel: Eucalyptus and what? Didn't catch that name. Oh, do you have the mints that I bought from you before? The least purchased ones. You always put them at the bottom of your box.

After the sounds of struggled searching, the owner at last pops his head back up, now covered with dust, and throws a faded iron box on the counter.

Newsstand Owner: Alright! Now, give my ticket back, and I'll put it away. I don't want any of the gangs to find out I'm dealing with the oth- ... Desert Flannel?

In front of him is an empty counter.

A coin purse has been placed on the abandoned newspaper, holding no coins but instead gray feathers.

Newsstand Owner: That's what I keep telling everyone.

Letting out a fatherly sigh, the newsstand owner lights up another cigarette.

Newsstand Owner: Muddying the water is what this bad girl does.

Makower: That's right. Desert Flannel has taken the fake tickets with her—the ones from Clippy, Slicky, and the Eucalyptus Brotherhood.

Makower: She's gone ... no, not to the black market.

Makower: ...

Makower: Sir, I heard that the Bunyips are getting restless again, is that true?

On the other end of the phone comes the noise of pinching a cigarette followed by laughter.

Hiding in the shadows in silence, the young girl darts past him.

Desert Flannel: Ha! I'm gonna make a fortune out of it!

Desert Flannel: I will be able to buy that house, get myself a new oven, some new clothes, and that giant wool nest for Plappy!

In a crash, some wet, black monsters flip over the well lid and crawl onto the road.

Desert Flannel: Urh, those Bunyips are out again. Haven't seen them out in the sun for a while now. I must hurry ...

Desert Flannel: Wait, are they coming my way?!

Makower: I've got my eyes on them. They are more interested in her than in me.

Desert Flannel: Well, this makes sense. Since the Uluru Games have made the biggest news of the week, the people are going on and on about it all day! And where else will the rumor-loving Bunyips go at this point?

Desert Flannel: Hah! The last time I saw something like this was when that scandal of Mr. Pompadour broke!

Makower: It will be a big story, almost as certainly as a cut will bleed.

Makower: I will pause my other projects and focus on this one.

Makower: This is very kind of you. I really appreciate it.

Desert Flannel: Nobody, nor any arcane creatures, can stop me from getting rich! Let alone that you haven't eaten enough rumors to grow into a three-floor high and multi-legged gigantic monster!

Desert Flannel: Bo-bo-bo-bo ... Plappy, give me a hand!

She swiftly takes a few steps back and presses the ON button on the digital pet device. A giant emu jumps out from the pixels, fluffing its feathers.

Plappy: Coo!!

Bunyip: Sss ... GARH!!

Desert Flannel: Ha! Like that "smell of rumors" from this ticket box? Come get it yourself!

The Torch Guardians III

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An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

The Buoy Balls · 2/2

RUG-05

Spathodea: Told you I'm super healthy! You should let me go now!

Ezra: But you need our care, Ms. Spathodea. It's also our responsibility to make sure that you're safe and stable.

Ezra: When arcanists were first introduced to their power, they would experience a 4-to-12-week adjustment period, during which they may suffer emotional breakdown, strong hallucinations, or frequent comas.

Spathodea: Hey, stop, stop it! I have something very important to do right now, I mean it!

Spathodea: I'm not gonna waste my time here! I'm fine! There will be no more confusion, mental breakdown, hallucination, or coma!

Vertin: Something very important? What is it?

The young girl stares at Ezra for a doubtful long time and finally talks.

Spathodea: My flame talked to me last night.

Flame: *steady breath*

The flame keeps hopping at a steady pace. Spathodea pets it like petting a curled kitty.

Spathodea: Now, it's asleep. I think it's exhausted after our rampage last night.

Vertin: Is the conversation about your changes?

Spathodea: Of course! The moment I touched it, it crawled along my arm to my mouth and went back to the stomach!

Spathodea: And-and all there's left in front of me was a black wall.

Vertin: Sorry, I'm not quite with you. Perhaps you could start from what happened then.

Spathodea: Sure! I don't remember it well, though.

Spathodea: They were blurry memories. Imagine you are looking at a plate of bacon and eggs through 30 layers of frosted glass. I had to get close to the glass to barely feel them.

Spathodea: I remembered you were there, and there was also a clear window.

Spathodea: I saw complete darkness in the window for most of the time, but there were pictures flashing by sometimes.

Ezra: I believe that's your memory as a "reincarnator"! Just like what's written in the books!

Spathodea: Hey! Let me finish!

Ezra: Ah, sorry. I was too excited because this is the first time I see a valid proof of "reincarnation." Please continue.

Spathodea: Ahem!

Spathodea: I think that's my memory, as a "reincarnator."

Spathodea: I saw my own body in that window, just like the one I'm looking at here.

Spathodea: I saw a lot of flames, wobbling lights, and people ...

The lively young girl takes a deep breath and presses her palm against her chest.

Spathodea: My heart has never beaten that fast, yet the fire in my body seemed completely natural, as if it was destined to burn inside me.

Spathodea: It whispered just one phrase to me, again and again.

Vertin: Like what you mentioned last night.

Spathodea: Yes, the Uluru Games. I must revive the Uluru Games.

Ezra: But, what are you going to do?

Ezra: Let's not get to the paper work of applications, security arrangement, and permission from the local government just yet.

Ezra: The location of entrance to the Uluru Games was never fixed. Only few arcanists could find it, and the Games are for arcanists only. There has never been a human athlete in there.

Ezra: And they have been canceled for all these years because they were completely lost in the war in 1942. Nobody has found them since.

Spathodea: But I can find it, because I have found my ancient self. I'm the only person in "this time" who has been to "that land" and my flame is my compass.

Spathodea throws back the covers and sits up on the bed.

Spathodea: Though I have not yet figured out why my memories are all about the conflicts with the flame, I felt so whole again when we burned together.

Spathodea: I'm sure it will help me and unite with me, because it trusts me so much that it traveled all the way here through the endless darkness and rainy seasons to come out of my mouth.

Spathodea: It's here for me, and now it's going to take me somewhere else.

Spathodea: I'll follow wherever it goes.

She seizes the cuff of the visitor, looking at her with her puppy dog eyes.

Spathodea: So, Vertin, you said you would take care of me. Would you come with me?

Spathodea: I need a Revival Squad and friends who understand and support each other, just the way the flame and I do! By then, you'll go to the Stadium too, and we'll run together!

Spathodea: I promise it will be a wonderful place where you'll never regret going. You will enjoy the Uluru Games!

Vertin: ...

Vertin: I have seen pictures of the Uluru Games in the school library collection a long time ago.

Vertin: I was not a fan of the routine physical fitness test at school, but I don't think any arcanist would say no to witnessing the revival of the once magnificent Games.

Spathodea: Oh, so?

Vertin: I'm more than willing to join you in bringing back the Games. It will be a wonderful new beginning.

A handshake is offered and accepted to symbolize their successful cooperation.

Spathodea: Wow! Yes! Thank you!

Ezra: I see. You're shouldering extremely important responsibility, Ms. Spathodea. I will apply for you to be discharged and explain all these to Judith!

Spathodea: Oh! And thank you Ezra! I won't forget your contribution to the revival of the Uluru Games!

Ezra: I'm deeply honored to have this chance to help.

Ezra: Then, I will get the paperwork done and go pack.

Spathodea: Hmm? What's that for?

Ezra: I need to prepare as many mushrooms as possible so that I can better assist you on the way.

Spathodea: You? On the way?

She points at herself and then at Ezra.

Spathodea: You're coming, too?

Ezra: Of course. We've been through so many things together. Am I not part of the team?

Spathodea: No, of course not! How can I take you in the Revival Squad?!

Spathodea: The Games is meant for arcanists. You've read the documents, right? Since the very beginning of history, humans have made countless attempts to find the entrance to the Stadium, yet none of them made it—it's just not for humans!

Spathodea: If you are a fan of sports, you can totally watch those held by humans! There will be a boxing event in Melbourne tomorrow, at the National Tennis Center at Flinders Park!

Ezra: No, no, Ms. Spathodea. I'm not interested in any games. The only reason why I'm coming along is because you haven't fully recovered and still need medical care.

Ezra: Besides, I hope to collect more information about "reincarnators" from you.

Ezra: I will not disturb your mission searching for the Stadium. Please, let me come with you. It's going to be good for both of us.

Spathodea: Collect information? You're monitoring me?

Spathodea: Sin-Since when did I grant you the permission to do that?! I never said yes!

Spathodea: I don't wanna be studied or published on newspaper, like the "reincarnator" you talked about!

Ezra: Our research does not need to be published on the newspaper. We can do it in a more subtle and secure manner.

Ezra: I will not design any tasks for you to perform, nor will I force you to take any potions. My job is to observe, record, and ensure your health and safety.

Ezra: Like what we do with the mushrooms.

Spathodea: But I'm a living arcanist, not a mushroom! I have had enough of everyone watching!

Looking up and down at Ezra, she hesitates and returns to her bed, wrapping herself up with the quilt like a burrito.

Spathodea: I don't wanna be the embellishment added to someone's academic achievement or a subject of the paper that will help you switch fields.

Ezra: Ah, I didn't explain it right.

Ezra: Ms. Spathodea, please listen to me. I have never changed my heart as a researcher, and I care about arcanists as much as I care about mushrooms. It was never my intention to use you as a career boost.

Ezra: You are such a rare opportunity to us, because none of us know when and where the next "reincarnator" will be found. If we miss this opportunity, the academic circle may have to wait for another decade to further their research.

Ezra: The discovery you and I made may shock many, our names might go down in history, but most importantly, it's going to help a lot of people!

Ezra: Have you heard of Tchangues invented by Dame Perotti? It was inspired by a long-legged shepherd in France, and it has helped many athletes with disabilities to walk and run again!

What a nice shot.

Spathodea: Ughhhh.

A long, painful moan escapes the little boxer's mouth.

Ezra: Ms. Spathodea? You look miserable in the blanket.

Vertin: Keep going, Ezra. You're very close ...

Ezra: Me? Close to what? I don't follow.

Desert Flannel: Close ... Well, speaking of close, guess who is close to becoming the most successful business person here?

Vertin: Desert Flannel? Where have you been?

Desert Flannel: Hi! What're the wide eyes for? I'm not some monster crawling out of the sewage.

She scrapes the mud from under her shoes and trots into the room, carrying three wooden boxes.

Spathodea: You look a mess. What happened?

Desert Flannel: Err, I didn't ask you why you are crouching in bed like an ostrich, did I? So maybe you can return the favor and keep your nose out of my business, yes?

Desert Flannel: And what really matters is the good stuff here!

Desert Flannel knocks on the cover of a box and is satisfied with the crisp sound.

Desert Flannel: You wouldn't know how unbelievably lucky we are, my dear business part- ... errr, friends.

Spathodea: Yeah, no. I don't.

Spathodea: *sighs* Ezra alone is already too much information for my brain.

Desert Flannel: Fine, you restless and humorless people.

Now hold tight and get ready. The rubber band is being stretched further and further above the box.

Desert Flannel: We will bring back the Uluru Games!

Spathodea: Hmph.

Ezra: Emm.

Vertin: ...

Desert Flannel: Hey! What kind of reaction is this? Why are you quiet as stones?

Desert Flannel: This is a great idea, and you're giving me this?!

In the room brimmed with wordless doubt and silence, a hand reaches up from beneath the quilt.

Spathodea: Alright, join my Revival Squad. Handshake? Handshake.

Ezra: Then I ...

Spathodea: No, not you!

Spathodea retracts her hand away from the burrito, in a movement so fast it blurs.

On the choppy water, several buoy balls are connected together. They are floating towards the depths of the pool hand in hand.

5#1

Day of Rebirth · 1/2

RUG-06

Spathodea: Mmm. Hey! I see it! Over there!

Spathodea: It's beautiful, even more beautiful than the one I saw in my dream.

Uluru Desert

A Grayhound bus closes its doors and drives away, honking and leaving the girls standing by the road in a puff of dust and smoke.

Desert Flannel: This is a miracle of nature like the Great Barrier Reef. Of course, it's pleasing to the eye.

Desert Flannel: Many would wrestle with the heatwave and travel all the way here from Alice Spring by bus.

Desert Flannel puts down her sunglasses on her head and flips her hair over her face.

Desert Flannel: Hah. I have to admit, it is worth the effort.

Vertin: The temperature here will get even higher at noon.

Vertin: Ezra has prepared plenty of Cooling Tablets and water in the medical kit for us. If anyone still suffers sunstroke, we also have the Budgerigar Coat as an emergency measure.

Spathodea: So that's why Ezra took you to the room before we left? To tell you all these?

Vertin: Ezra is worried about you, and so are we.

Spathodea: Hmph.

Desert Flannel: Ooh. Someone is feeling bad about what she said earlier.

Desert Flannel: If you ask me, that human girl has a good heart. Maybe she can work on her ways of communicating with people, but that altruism in her is almost angel-like.

Desert Flannel: And she has the face of a little angel. Wouldn't be such a bad idea to put her in some baby care commercials. I heard those things pay you generously. I might as well ask what she thinks.

Vertin: Huh?

Flame: Go forward.

Spathodea: Wow! It's talking again!

Desert Flannel: What? Who's talking again?

Spathodea: The flame! It's talking! Didn't you hear it?!

Desert Flannel: Nah, it sounds the same to me. This is just the sound of fire burning, snoring, like my late old man.

Desert Flannel: Well, maybe you can also try turning off this little thingy's TV. Maybe it will jump up and shout "I'm still watching."

Spathodea: I'm not joking! It's really talking! Listen!

Lifting the flame with both of her hands, Spathodea puts it as close to Desert Flannel's ear as possible.

Flame: ...

Desert Flannel looks more and more alarmed in the silence.

Desert Flannel: Wait. Its temperature has gone up, and ... it's transforming? What is this, a rocket?

Flame: No more waiting.

Spathodea: Whoa!

As swift as an arrow, the burning fireball radiating heat waves flies towards the other side of the desert.

Spathodea: Hey, hang on! Where are you going?!

Spathodea: I thought we were good friends! Are you ditching me already?!

The agile Spathodea is the first to catch up with the flame.

Behind them, the Grayhound bus in the distance is starting again.

Vertin: Everyone, mind your steps and keep up!

Desert Flannel: A race in the desert. Great. I wonder why I'm not as clever and creative as you are.

The noisy crowd has gone. Where they once were, a slim figure pops out of a tree.

Ezra: Ms. Vertin ... Was she talking to me? She always looks over, perhaps she knows that I'm following them.

Ezra: But ... no. I'm hiding well. They shouldn't know.

Mumbling, Ezra sketches a fire pattern into his notebook.

Ezra: Having emotional turmoil, acting impulsively, feeling fanatical about the retrieved memories ... and the unstoppable urge to return to the "homeland."

Ezra: These all match the description in the research notes.

Ezra: And now, the fire, which is also the key in this case, is burning vigorously.

Ezra: The notes end here. That's all we know about "reincarnators."

Looking up into the distance, Ezra walks from one bush to another.

Ezra: I can't deduce more based on the current data, but at the same time, the unknown can be dangerous yet exciting. It might bring about catastrophes or miracles.

Ezra: Just like arcanists, so charming and lively.

Ezra: My job is to help and protect them, so their burning enthusiasm will not be dampened. Like what Mom said, this is our mission as mankind.

The human child once again opens the backpack and checks it for the 1,001st time.

Ezra: The Annular Jumper Frog Mushroom, the Fairy Ring Powders, and the Butterfly-shaped Portobello Mushroom ... Very well, I have them all. This time, I'm prepared for any danger.

Spathodea: Hah! Gotcha! You are not running away from ...

Flame: This is ... the beginning ... of the journey.

Spathodea: Beginning of the journey? No, we set off from Melbourne!

Spathodea: We're close to Uluru now, so it's almost our destin- ...

Spathodea: Gosh, what are these?

Vertin: These are murals. No, they are reliefs. All the marks are carved out of the wall.

Vertin: These carvings existed long before any murals, and they are rougher.

Desert Flannel: Of course, they are. Just think, when did our ancestors learn to draw with paints? And when did they start carving with sharp stones?

Spathodea: They are beautiful, like star trails, one circle in another.

Spathodea: I think I've seen them before. They feel familiar and make me thirsty at the same time. Look, this circle is just like a spring.

Desert Flannel: We don't need a spring. We brought water ourselves. Drink as much as you want.

Desert Flannel: Hmm. Look here. These are most probably some ancient relics. This one looks like an animal, and this, a plant!

Desert Flannel: Emm? And what is this, a birdy?

Vertin: They have something to do with people's lives. These marks have to mean something.

Vertin: Maybe they will lead us to the entrance to the Stadium.

Desert Flannel: This is the time when Spathodea's opinion matters more than ours. Come, key girl, take a look at this.

But they can't find the girl who was talking about her thirst anywhere. The water leaking from the fallen dusty-covered cup is absorbed into the hot sand.

Desert Flannel: Spathodea? Where, where did she go?

Desert Flannel: And that fire, they are all gone!

Desert Flannel: What the hell is going on again? She'd better be pulling a prank on me. I heard her footsteps behind me just now.

Vertin: Relax, Desert Flannel. We've got help.

A slim figure emerges from behind the tree.

Desert Flannel: Ezra? How, how did you get here? Wait, how long have you been following us?

Ezra: From the beginning, when you were at the hospital. Sorry, Ms. Desert Flannel, please let me check this first.

Ezra frowns, quickening his pace when nearing the wall of reliefs.

Some mushrooms break into pieces under the pressure and release a pungent scent of spores.

Ezra: This smell ... I can't be wrong—This is Devil's Thorn.

Desert Flannel: What's that? Does it have anything to do with her missing?

Ezra: A rare kind of mushroom that grows in the desert. Allegedly, it's genetically connected to lizards. I've only seen its pictures in books.

Ezra: It has wide, open pileus with sharp spikes, and its roots are as absorbent as sponge, which allows it to absorb and preserve underground water. They only appear around water sources, and with this spiral pattern on the wall, I think ...

Ezra: I think I might have a way to find her.

Ezra: Ezra stands up and takes out a metal dowsing rod from his pocket.

Ezra: Please come with me.

Thirst. She felt the dry thirst throughout her body. As if she had never taken even a single sip of water, or she was a beast that must keep running and running for its survival.

A gout of flame pierces through the formless dark.

Spathodea: Little flame?

Spathodea: *coughs* My throat ... It hurts ... Water ...

Flame: Do you remember me?

The fire pulses and comes closer to her, like a beating heart.

Flame: I traveled through the endless flood, drought, rain, and waterfalls to finally reach you.

Flame: Do you remember me?

Spathodea: I ...

Her dry throat keeps twitching as if a toad was resting there.

Spathodea: I do, but ... not really ...

Spathodea: I can't recall your name or your face, but I do remember ...

She curls up in a tight ball. Her palms and feet getting hotter and hotter.

Flame: Do you remember our fight?

The boiling raindrops mixed with fire are splashed on her spine.

Together, they pour into her dry throat.

Spathodea: Ugh!

She is not sure if she is standing or crawling on the ground. The only thing she can do is breathe like a fish.

The fire flows from the back of her ears to her eyes, like a warm hug from behind.

Spathodea: "Weigh the anchor of the current feelings and seek in the boundless net."

She hears a different voice coming from her own throat.

Spathodea: "Seek me, seek the past, seek the intelligence and spirit we are bound to find."

Spathodea: I don't wanna make up with you! You dumb ball of fire!

Spathodea: "Neither do I, you stupid girl!"

Spathodea: My hands are burning, like they are soaked in fire.

Spathodea: "That's because you reached into me. We had a fight, attacking each other with nails like two cats."

Spathodea: Ah! This is just like the day we first met!

The scene in her mind becomes clear. She can see the clue of this ancient memory within her reach.

Spathodea: I can feel my knees trembling again.

Spathodea: I know this game, a sport which is not popular enough to be included in any commercial or professional games.

Spathodea: It's also the sport for which I've been secretly training myself every day after lunch—the light-bulbs-picking game, Malingee's Harvest ... No, no.

Spathodea: But these are not light bulbs for the athletes to pick up from the ground, but fire ... And I don't have such a burning campfire at home. It can only be found here.

Spathodea: Beside the flowing spring, under the starry sky, on the scorching sand, I saw the burning campfire and the sparks scattering in all directions.

Spathodea: My hands surrounded by blazing flames, I touched the inner cone again and again as I flew by. Immersed in great joy, I dove down from the air.

Spathodea: "At that time, our hands held each other in the flames."

Spathodea: "Our traces went on from one torch to another."

Spathodea: Yes, I know. I remember it now.

Spathodea: I once drank the cold water in the spring and covered my limbs with colorful strips. I sang and danced until a pair of wrinkled hands touched my forehead.

An elderly man staggers to his feet and rises from the depths of the dark cave.

Priest: Good girl, my good girl ...

Priest: Your hands are dusted, but you win the game, and your soul is sparkling. It's you who find the hottest fire for us! It's you who connect to it and make friends with it!

Priest: I shall grant you the scepter and lead you to the highest platform.

Spathodea: I shall become the next Priestess of the Uluru Temple.

Spathodea: I shall take responsibility for every drop of sweat on the red soil, and I shall eulogize all the significant, fair competitions.

Spathodea: I shall store the flame in my mouth, my stomach, my heart, and my ribs.

Spathodea: I shall protect her, not to let her extinguish, nor to let her go astray or away.

Spathodea: I hereby swear ...

Spathodea: I shall be with the Uluru Games, until ... forever.

Spathodea: M-Mom ...

Spathodea: M-M-Mom never told me ... w-w-we are descendants of the Red Dragon ...

Uluru spring

Critter: *roars*

Spathodea: Ah?! I-I'm awake now. This is the entrance to the Stadium!

Spathodea: Then that howl must be ...

The girl bends and rolls on the ground in a circle to avoid the sharp claws' attack.

Spathodea: The guardians of the Stadium, I knew it! *coughs*

Spathodea: I'm too weary to stand up! Shoot, there's no way I can beat them just rolling around!

Ezra: Ms. Spathodea!

Spathodea: E-Ezra?! And Desert Flannel, Vertin!

Spathodea: Thank goodness you found me!

Ezra: These critters—they don't look like any kind that I know of. What are they ...

Critter: *hiss*

Facing the boulders thrown by the critters, Spathodea does a forward roll and hides behind a shelter.

Spathodea: These critters are the guardians of the Stadium! They are ... Ugh, I can explain it later. We have to deal with them first!

Spathodea: Hmm? Little flame?! Hey! What are you doing?!

The little flame floats leisurely toward the monsters.

Vertin: No time to hesitate. Protect Spathodea and engage!

The Torch Guardians IV

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An advertisement from the ads page of Wall Street Journal.

> Come to C.C Critter Pawnshop to make extra money!
> TEL: 847-6861XXX
>
> Are the cunning, ubiquitous critters annoying you again? Don't take that as bad news, because if you have a critter, you just found yourself enough money to pay your rent! We offer the best, the most precise, and the most honest pricing options you'll ever find! Our shop will buy any critters from the cheapest Carbuncles to the expensive yet delicious Rubberados that keep diners bouncing about! C.C swears on its name that every critter we buy will be treated like a family in compliance with internationally recognized standards of humane treatment!

Day of Rebirth · 2/2

RUG-06

Ezra: Great, they are down!

Ezra: Everyone, for the sake of prudence, please stay back and do not approach before confirming the danger has been eliminated.

Spathodea: No, there's no more danger now. Look!

A heated current of air surges from the top of Uluru Rock to the spring by the people's feet.

Among the remains of a guardian critter, a bone torch is engulfed in the flame.

Flame: No need to worry or hesitate.

The scorching heat storms around.

Spathodea: Now, it's all clear!

Spathodea: Long story short, mates, I've retrieved many memories. At least now I know who I used to be.

Spathodea: My name in the last life was Flammy, exactly what my close ones call me now.

Spathodea: I am still ME. I'm not replaced by anyone.

Ezra: You are still you, the modern version ...

Ezra: This has never happened to any "reincarnators" as far as we know!

Spathodea: That's because Flammy and I are very alike, and we both have the same duty on our shoulders.

Spathodea: ...

Spathodea: I am Flammy. I obtained the Uluru Flame from the fire with my own hands. I was the first Priestess in the history of the Uluru Games.

Flame: I am Spathodea. I keep the flame that traveled all the way from the ancient times inside me. I will become the next Priestess in the history of the Uluru Games.

The flame is no longer the small flame as it was. Now, it is roaring like a beast, rearing up into the sky.

Spathodea: Remember what I said, mates? My flame is our compass!

Spathodea: Mom said good kids never lie. So, I always keep my word!

Spathodea: Spathodea looks back and gives them a grin.

In an instant, she hurries her pace and jumps into the fire.

5#1

The Old Flame

RUG-07

Desert Flannel: Spathodea! Spathodea! Where, where did she go?!

???: It was like a long slumber, or a view of the garden behind the wall.

A new voice is heard coming alongside a gust of cold wind, blowing away the thick steam.

???: But now, I finally get to see the sun again. The world out there has completely changed.

The person made of fire opens her eyes. They are also filled with flame.

???: But you remain the same, Flammy, my dear friend.

???: You found me, and put an end to the long, dark dream. You set me on fire again, bringing me back to what a flame should be like.

Spathodea: Welcome to the end of the 20th century, Ulu.

Spathodea: For you, this is an interesting era with many many new things. Well, I think we can learn them together later, one by one!

Spathodea: While for my dear brave friends ...

Spathodea: Welcome to the Uluru Games, my dear brave friends!

The giant heavy gate opens with winds blowing out from inside.

The team members go through the gate one after another. Ezra, however, remains still like a statue.

Spathodea: What are you waiting for?

Ezra: The conjuring of the entrance to the Uluru Stadium is sourced from a fantastic arcane ritual. Instead of a summon, it's closer to a sacrifice ...

Ezra: The fire element also plays an important part in this sacrifice. In Spathodea's case, Ulu is her flame.

Ezra: Will it have anything to do with the unique condition Ms. Spathodea has? Unlike other "reincarnators," she still has a clear memory of this life, despite her young age.

Ezra: Or, it's because that two light spots of hers—the older self and the modern self—are not that different, so she's spared going through any drastic changes, and the reason behind it might be ...

Spathodea: Ezra!!!

Ezra: ...! Yes, I'm here!

Ezra blinks several times, like a frightened animal, slowly looking up from the notebook.

Ezra: What can I do for you, Ms. Spathodea?

Spathodea: I'm waiting for you.

Ezra: Ah, I see. Sorry, I was too involved in taking notes.

Ezra: I will pack and return to Laplace as soon as possible. But before that ...

After looking around a few times, Ezra pats his chest.

Ezra: I have to clean up the spores and the mess we made in the battle first; otherwise, they may change the environment here.

Spathodea: Oh, c'mon, you weirdo!

Spathodea: You're leaving now, after all our effort? I can never understand you!

Ezra: Aren't you waiting for me to leave?

Spathodea: Of course not! I'm waiting for you to join us. We'll go into the Stadium together!

Spathodea: I ...

Spathodea: Come to think about what I have suffered: coma, hallucination, confusion, thirst, misconception that I was almighty, and then, as you can see, I fell into a coma again after my sudden disappearance.

Spathodea: I think you're right. I do need a doctor by my side!

Ezra: But mankind cannot enter the Stadium. We all know thaaaaaat ...!

An arm suddenly yanks Ezra into the gate.

Spathodea: Ugh blah blah blah! Please, the Stadium has never shown itself to any humans before!

Spathodea: When life gives you cake, just dig right in!

After the girl hops through it, the magnificent gate closes with a mighty snap.

Uluru Stadium

Ezra: Strewth! This is the Uluru Stadium?

Vertin: It's even more splendid than I thought, and ... more comfortable and pleasing.

Ezra: Comfortable and pleasing?

Ezra: I don't feel the same way as you do.

Ezra takes a few steps ahead and matches them with deep breaths.

Ezra: But not in the sense that this place doesn't look beautiful to me, on the contrary, it's stunning, but physically I don't feel anything special.

Desert Flannel: Maybe because you're a human. Hey, wait!

Ezra: Mmm! Not so fast, be careful! Ms. Desert Flannel, you will fall!

Desert Flannel: I won't, I won't!

Desert Flannel stretches herself and suddenly steps firmly on the ground, running like an arrow toward Spathodea, who has already reached the other end of the field.

Desert Flannel: I'm feeling as light as the wind and even more energetic than when I finished a big meal of steak and cakes!

Desert Flannel: I may fall anytime anywhere, but not now, not here!

Ulu: This is exactly what arcanists should feel.

Ezra: Ms. Ulu! Ah, pardon me. May I call you that?

Ulu: Go ahead if you want, child.

Ulu: But of course, I would appreciate it if you call me Madam, since I'm a few hundred years older than all of you. Besides, I am the most sacred flame of the Games ... Hmm?!

Spathodea: Hah! I won! Been a long time since I had so much fun running!

Despite interrupting the conversation, Spathodea seems unfazed and keeps asking questions endlessly.

Spathodea: Ulu! Is that a lawn? We didn't have anything like that before! And those benches!

Ulu: Things change, Flammy.

Ulu: In the past hundreds of years when you were absent, countless changes happened to the Uluru Games.

Ulu: New lawns and benches had somehow appeared in the Stadium, but none of these changes was made by arcanists.

Ulu: Those actually made by arcanists were new events, new rules, and new management. These are the changes that really made the Uluru Games different.

Spathodea: I see. No wonder I've never seen Ice Racewalking in my memories! Let me see, so there was no Stone Throw Divination or New Tridecathlon either ...

Ezra: Ice Racewalking is not a traditional sport in Australia. It originated from Northern Europe and became popular in cold countries.

Ulu: That's right. Ice Racewalking was introduced to the Games in 1926.

Ulu: If my memory serves me well, it was introduced by the St. Pavlov Foundation. On one hand, they hoped to show the internationality and inclusiveness of the Games; on the other ...

Ezra: On the other?

Ulu: Well ... it took the place of Fire Racewalking.

Ezra: I see, I read it somewhere before. At the beginning of the 20th century, after St. Pavlov Foundation took over the Uluru Games, some challenging and relatively dangerous sports were canceled.

Ezra: This was also the turning point of the Uluru Games. From then on, the Games declined in popularity, and fewer and fewer athletes came each year.

Spathodea: Humph, these people ... No, these idiots! They know nothing about the essence of arcanists' sporting event!

Spathodea: Where on earth can you find an arcanist who would burn their own legs in Fire Racewalking?! Everyone knows you'll be fine as long as you believe the fire is harmless!

Ezra: But, in point of fact, fire is dangerous.

Ezra replies in a whisper and looks up, checking the roof from left to right.

Spathodea: But think about it. It's unbelievable! Given your short fuse, I can't believe you just let them cancel your favorite event, Ulu.

Ezra: Short ... fuse?

Spathodea: Yeah, you heard it right! She's got the hottest temper! Burns like herself!

Ulu: Ahem! AHEM!!!

Ulu: Things change, Flammy! I ... have already spent over a thousand years in this world. I'm no longer the young, hotheaded flame of your age!

Ulu: Even your grandmother should call me Grandma now!

Spathodea: Grandma? So they can just take away your favorite event just because you're old now? I don't understand!

Walking a few steps away, Spathodea clenches her fists in anger.

Spathodea: Anyway, Flammy is back! It's time arcanists took back the Uluru Games from the Foundation! Let's design a new list of events that fit real arcanists!

Spathodea: We'll start from Fire Racewalking. There are woods here. Ulu can start some bonfires with them ...

Desert Flannel: Will the Foundation agree to this? They seem difficult to deal with.

Ezra: It's hard to take it over from the Foundation, but if we have all the security-related facilities prepared, and apply to host the event through Laplace Scientific Computing Center ...

Vertin: Considering Spathodea's identity, we do stand a chance.

Vertin: But the paperwork we are going to deal with ...

Spathodea: Oh, c'mon! COME ON! You are not supposed to talk about paperwork in the sacred Uluru Stadium!

Spathodea: Instead of a bunch of weak office workers who would pant from climbing a few stairs, what I need is some real athletes who can help me complete the Fire Racewalking!

Spathodea: I don't mind whether they are cute or weird, I only need them to be energetic! This is the only thing we ask of athletes in this sport ...

Desert Flannel: Great idea. But the only inconvenience is that we are in the middle of the desert, a place where only flies visit.

Desert Flannel: And as I checked my contact list, I saw only ... client, client, and client ... the ordinary ones and the ones I once stood up. Where are we going to find the athletes?

Vertin: Well, I happen to know many arcanists who meet your need.

Vertin: And they happen to be here right now.

Spathodea: What? How come I can't see them anywhere?

Spathodea: Hmm? Why are you opening the suitcase? Are you gonna organize your stuff here?

Open the suitcase, place it on the ground, and knock on the edge. A knocking sound echoes in the black space.

Vertin: Anyone care to have some fresh air?

The other three standing around the suitcase look more puzzled. Spathodea tentatively opens her mouth but shuts it once again.

Soon a clear clip-clop comes from the bottomless suitcase.

Darley Clatter: *neigh*

The first thing they see is a silky, shining horse with a mane fluttering in the wind.

Darley Clatter: The fresh smell of grass with smoked fragrance! There is no doubt that it tastes better than gilded carrots!

Darley Clatter: And, look at this army of royal guards!

Darley Clatter: They must be here to greet the Great Darley Clatter!

Desert Flannel: Royal guards? What is he saying? Aaah ... no kidding, is that giant creature covered with spikes his "Royal Guard"?

Thorny Lizard: *roaring*

A deep, angry roar comes from the depths of the Stadium.

Ulu: That's the thorny devils, the enormous creatures born in the burning sand of the Stadium. They used to be mounts for the players, but looks like they have forgotten their master after all these years of slumber.

Ulu: Enough talk. Let's put them back to dust and ashes.

Desert Flannel: Yes! Another great victory! And I dedicate this win to Ms. Spathodea!

Spathodea: And to Ms. Desert Flannel!

Surrounded by the fiery atmosphere, the girls raise an invisible glass to each other.

Desert Flannel grabs Spathodea's wrist and lifts it up like a referee, calling out to the suitcase, out of which more arcanists pour out.

Desert Flannel: Now, people ... those of you who are not afraid of fire and wish to walk among the flames, please register here!

5#1

Triple Zero

RUG-08

Ulu: Good! You're doing great! Faster, higher!

A grandma can be crazy about sports too. Give her time, and she will burn like the sun.

Spathodea: Yes! Ulu, you are exactly the Ulu I knew in my memory!

Spathodea: Fire Racewalking, Apparate 400 Meters, Branch Vault, and Malingee's Harvest ... We have brought back so many old games!

Spathodea: Oh, I have to go! The Bunny Bunny Arm Wrestling is about to start!

Games after games, ideas after ideas.

Both active and inactive arcanists find their own happiness on this field.

Ezra: The people are having a good time here. They are sweaty but also delighted. I've never seen anything like this in Laplace.

Once again, Ezra looks up at the shabby rooftop.

Ezra: As Ms. Ulu said, this excitement comes from the Stadium itself. Is this a recovery arcane skill that works on arcanists? Or, a kind of cheering potion?

Vertin: No, I don't think so. It just smells ... familiar here.

Regulus: Yes! Right! Totally agree with you!

Regulus: It smells like the, uh, the weird cave on that island ... burp! Hmm?

Regulus: Oh, I smell beef, with tomato and mixed grilling sauce ... Oh! It must be my tomato steak flavor potato crisp. Haha! This is great fun!

Regulus: I didn't touch a drop, but, ah, feeling dizzy!

Vertin: Watch out, Regulus. You are falling down.

Supported by a pair of friendly arms, the Rockin' Pirate softly jumps like a long, thin jelly.

Regulus: Oh? Are you saying that a sports game can narcotize people, too? Hmm. I think Mr. APPLe knows it better than me. Let me check where he is.

Despite her weakness, the pirate's excitement is not dampened. She's in a "jelly" mood to explore.

Vertin: Mmm?!

Regulus: I see him! I see a red ball. Oh! That must be Mr. APPLe! But, but he seems rounder and bigger.

While Vertin is trying to keep a drunk Regulus balanced, the game on the other side of the Stadium has come to an end. Spathodea wipes the sweat off her forehead with rosy cheeks and eyes sparkling.

Bunny Bunny: Time's up! And the victory goes to—Ms. Desert Flannel!

Desert Flannel: Ha ...! I told ya, no one beats me at arm-wrestling!

Spathodea: *pants* Ugh, I lost ... You are so strong!

Spathodea: The strongest I have ever ... Ugh ...

Spathodea bounces up like a spring.

And immediately slumps down.

Desert Flannel: Spathodea!

Desert Flannel: You alright? Hey ... wake up! Go, get me the wet towel!

Folding the towel and putting it on that rosy girl's forehead has become a routine to Desert Flannel. After finishing this, she fans her with her own jacket.

Vertin: Her temperature ... is a bit lower than just now, but her condition is quite stable. I guess it's not a "reincarnator" reaction, but something else.

Darley Clatter: *sniff*

Darley Clatter: Is she alright? She feels hot, but not as hot as the horseshoe made of pure gold.

Desert Flannel: I'm positive that she was once a lot hotter than your little hooves are right now.

Desert Flannel: She was a walking fire that burned fiercely, the forest-destroying kind.

Darley Clatter: Neigh?!

The wooden horse whinnies in panic and rolls backward on its squeaky metal wheels.

Ezra: Please don't panic. I have not observed any signs of flame in her eyes or mouth. She's not ablaze again.

Ezra: Ms. Desert Flannel, did she have any abnormalities before she passed out?

Desert Flannel: Abnormalities? Some, I think. She waddled as if she was pissed, and talked so loudly that anyone could tell she wasn't in a clear mind ...

Vertin: Drunk, clouding of consciousness ... No, Regulus!

Regulus: You look like an apple-color giant rock, Mr. APPLe! You are so big, and our ship is so small.

Ulu: I'm feeling so good ... and inspired! *deep breath*

Standing next to a tremendous ball of fire, the Rockin' Pirate has never felt this small before.

Regulus: *exhales* Ah? Huh? Seems your change of size changes your voice as well.

Regulus: But! Since you get this huge, we can strike those old fogeys in London like a meteor! On top of the world, there will be our flag of Rock 'n' Roll!

Regulus: Come! Come to me—I require the biggest huuuuug!

But it's not a good idea to have any hugs with fire.

Vertin: Regulus!

Regulus: Whoaa!! It's hot! It's burning!! It's burning my hands!

Because they are scorching, unstable, and fiery.

Ulu: Go beyond your limits! Your sweat is the best eulogy for the red land!

Ezra: That's Ms. Ulu! She's out of control! Is this ... Also a result of the Stadium's power?!

Bunny Bunny: Oh, my! Ms. Regulus! Be careful!

The fireball grows bigger and bigger. Bunny Bunny runs to Regulus and grabs her sleeve.

Regulus: Ah, I'm so tired. Let me take a nap.

Bunny Bunny: Regulus? Regulus! Oh, dear ... Don't pass out now! I'm getting you outta here, just a sec!

Regulus: Zzzz ...

Ezra: Another one has passed out. If we let it go on like this, every arcanist here would ... Ms. Vertin, we have to leave at once!

Bunny Bunny: But Ms. Spathodea has passed out, too! Who can open that door?

Vertin: Bunny Bunny, take everyone back to the suitcase!

Vertin: Don't let anyone out before I open it again!

Bunny Bunny: Alright, got it ... Oops! I got tripped by ... Huh?! Mr. APPLe! Why are you sleeping in the grass?

Darley Clatter: Darley is on it!

With Click on his back and APPLe in his mouth, Darley Clatter pushes La Source into the suitcase and jumps inside after her. Clang. The suitcase closes, blocking the fire from a full room of arcanists.

Ulu: All the fun, the fun of sports! I am burning like I did a thousand years ago!

Ulu: Haha ... Let's dance hand in hand, for the respectable sunshine ... and rain!

Fire is always scorching, not to mention the Uluru Flame which has been burning for a thousand years.

She emits her heat like she did as a newborn baby. Smoke coming billowing from the soil, even the beast bones inside eventually burn.

Ezra: Mmm. This is too dangerous. She may start a fire!

Vertin: We have to put her out for now.

Ezra turns to Vertin. They both remember what happened that night at the park.

Vertin: ... The good news is, we are already a skilled fire brigade.

5#1

The Superman

RUG-09

inside the suitcase

Vertin: Desert Flannel's dizziness is in remission. She's already well enough to deal with her business on the fax machine. Will it do harm to her physical condition?

Ezra: Ms. Desert Flannel is only experiencing a very mild reaction. She can move around freely, and it is recommended for her to do so. Ms. Spathodea, on the contrary ...

Vertin: She's not even awake.

Ezra: No. But her body temperature and her arcanum level are getting stable now. She should wake up in any minute.

Vertin: Is it because she took part in too many events in the Stadium?

Ezra: That's right. She has to stay in bed for the next three days.

Ezra: As well as Ms. Regulus and Mr. APPLe. I have asked Ms. Bunny to send them the medicine. If everything went well, they should have woken up by now ...

Bunny Bunny: Dr. Ezra, I'm back!

The bunny girl pops out from between the crack in the door.

Bunny Bunny: Both Mr. APPLe and Ms. Regulus are awake now, so I gave them some medicine! But ... Ms. Ulu is still in a coma ...

Ezra: Don't worry, Ms. Ulu is different to the other unconscious arcanists. She was weakened by the long sleep, while the other arcanists lost consciousness because of external factors.

Ezra: Look, this is their physiological data in the last three hours.

Ezra: Many arcanists have told us that their physical abilities were improved as they entered the Stadium. They felt they were in a refreshed state like they had a good sleep or rested properly.

Ezra: But after they competed in 4 to 6 different games, or the average sporting time exceeded 3.5 hours, they would feel dizzy, as if they had consumed too much alcohol.

Vertin: And these symptoms were relieved soon after they left the Stadium.

Bunny Bunny: Ah, you mean ... people are in oblivion because of that ... Stadium?

Bunny Bunny: If that place is so dangerous, is it possible to hold the Games again?

Ezra: I think this is why in the past, athletes were only allowed to compete in three different sports. As long as we stick with the same rule, the safety of our athletes shouldn't be problematic.

Bunny Bunny: Oh! I got it! So this place is just as safe as the club I work in! As long as we ain't breaking the rules, nothing will happen!

Bunny Bunny: Like how the bodyguards and I take care of our club, the rule and special medicine made by Ms. Ezra will protect the Uluru Stadium!

Vertin: ...

Ezra: Ms.?

Bunny Bunny: Oh? What's wrong, Ms. Ezra?

Ezra: Ms. Bunny, but you see ... I'm not a Ms.

Bunny Bunny: Huh?

Bunny Bunny slowly tilts her head.

Bunny Bunny: You are funny, Ms. Ezra. Please stop teasing me. What else can you be except a lady? A gentleman?

Vertin: Ezra is indeed a he.

Bunny Bunny: ... Huh?

The bunny girl's voice starts to sound hesitant.

Spathodea: A-A HE?!

Ezra: Aah! Ms. Spathodea, you're awake! Here, take this water and the nutrition supplement capsule.

Spathodea: No no no no, NOOOO ...

Spathodea, hands trembling, pushes away the pills and water.

Spathodea: You-You're a boy? When did you ... turn into a boy?

Ezra: Yes, I'm a boy. I was a boy when I was born, and I have been that way since.

Spathodea: What? Wait ... Wh-What? Why did you lie to me?! Why did you say you were a ... Wait, you never said you were a girl ...

Ezra: Wait, Ms. Spathodea, please don't grab me so tightly.

Desert Flannel: Hey ya, I'm back ... Emm? What happened?

Desert Flannel: Our little Spathodea looks completely absent-minded, arms around her knees, and Missy Ezra here is holding her forehead and looks ... overwhelmed?

Spathodea: She ... Um, he! He is not a "missy"! He's a buddy!

Desert Flannel: Aah ... Buddy Ezra? So what, boy or girl, is that such a big deal?

Desert Flannel waves the papers around and puts them on the table in front of Spathodea.

Desert Flannel: Nothing is more important than this!

Spathodea: "Dear Ms. Vertin, I am glad to hear from you ..."

Desert Flannel: No no, not that one. That's for Vertin ... from some guy called Slouch Hat.

She fishes out a page out of the pile in Spathodea's hand and throws it to Vertin.

Vertin: Oh, thank you. He's my contact in Australia. We've been writing letters these days.

Spathodea: So what am I supposed to look at then? This one?

Spathodea: Large-scale Event Application Form ... Alice Springs Government ... Oh! This is! This is that thing!

Desert Flannel: Haha! Yeees! We just need to go to the City Hall, fill in the form, and submit it! Then we're ready to have our Uluru Games!

Spathodea: What are we waiting for then? Let's hit the road!

She throws back the covers and leaps out of the bed.

Ezra: No! Ms. Spathodea! You haven't fully recovered. You need to rest!

Spathodea: I'm not feeling that bad ... Actually I'm feeling really good! That's right—reeeally good!

The little girl grips the arm of her doctor and gives him a rough shake.

Spathodea: The City Hall is not like a no man's land. We're just going there to fill in some forms. They won't hurt me, okay? O-kay?

Ezra: No ... NO. This time is different.

The doctor tries to stay solid as a rock amidst the storm of shaking.

Ezra: This is not like what happened before, Ms. Spathodea!

Ezra: I'm your doctor, and I'm responsible for your health. I can't let you leave my sight.

Spathodea: Your sight ... Your sight ... Oh! Got it!

Spathodea stopped shaking but began pulling hard instead.

Spathodea: You can come with me! C'mon, c'mon!

Spathodea: Time waits for no man. Our Summer Games are about to start!

Ezra: Wa-Wait ... Whaaah!

The kids disappear at the end of the hallway, their yells and shouts lingering a little longer.

Bunny Bunny: Whoa ... Ms. Spathodea is surely a good runner, even faster than the potion-drunk Ms. Sotheby ...

Desert Flannel: OK, since the doctor and the patient are both happy, I, the event assistance producer, am also hitting the road!

Desert Flannel: Wait for our good news!

Alice Springs City Government

Desert Flannel: What are these? And this?! Look, I know English, but I don't understand any of the things written here.

Desert Flannel: What is "Northern Territory Event Security Law"? And what is "Type III Field Safety Certification"?

Desert Flannel: I think I will just go with C here for Event Types. That's what looks closest to the Uluru Games, since they're both two-word phrases ...

Spathodea: Maybe, let's just go with that one.

Spathodea: I always go with C when I have no idea what I'm reading ...

Desert Flannel buries her head in her hands, wailing, while Spathodea keeps biting her pencil.

Bunny Bunny: Mass Event Application, Fire Escape Plan ... Ms. Spathodea, does the Stadium have a fire escape?

Spathodea: ... Not in Flammy's memory. Let me check Spathodea's ... Alright, I have no idea at all. The sports are all that I care about ...

Bunny Bunny: Well ... I'm just gonna write down an "unknown" here ...

Ezra: ...

Ezra: You ...

Desert Flannel: How are ya, my grumpy little friend? Finally made up your mind to help?

Ezra opens and shuts his mouth, shaking his head roughly.

At ease as he seems, deep down he is like a cat on hot bricks.

Ezra: No ... I have no desire to help a patient who doesn't care about her own health. You are on your own.

Government Staff: City Government Service Center, District B, Window 13 at your service. Thanks for your waiting. Your form will be exami- ...

Government Staff: ...

Desert Flannel: Oh, great, she stopped. What happened?

Spathodea: That's not a good look. I've seen that look on Ms. Judy's face. She's my maths teacher ... Whenever she puts on that face ...

Desert Flannel: Yes?

Spathodea: It means "none of your answers are correct!"

Desert Flannel: A-ha ...

Failure.

A sheet of paper stained with ink is returned, and its owners talk to each other, walking away from the service window.

Spathodea: Told you we can't fill "Who knows" in the form ...

Desert Flannel: Who knows you can't write that!

Spathodea: Please check this one.

Government Staff: Yes, Ms. Desert ... I'm sorry, and you are ...

Spathodea: Hellooo! I am Spathodea, the director of the event!

Spathodea: This counter is wayyy too high! Should've let Desert Flannellll talk to you!

Spathodea: But she'ssss feeling sick after reading the form!

Spathodea: Sooooo, I have to do it insteaaaad!

Government Staff: ... I will prepare a stool for you. Please stop jumping.

Another failure.

Her form failed, that is true, but at least she gets a stool to step onto.

Spathodea: Ugh! Yes, with this stool, I don't have to jump up again and again!

Spathodea: Here's the form we revised. Please check it!

Government Staff: ... Alright.

Government Staff: You've submitted the Arcanist Gathering Registration Form, the Mass Events Application Form, and the Desert Areas Gathering Application Form.

Government Staff: Your application will be in the approval process very soon.

Spathodea: Gosh, YESSS! I'd go crazy if I had to fill in them again!

Spathodea: I've never experienced such pain. We cried on each other's shoulder several times!

Government Staff: Same for me.

Spathodea: I'm sorry?

Government Staff: It's nothing. But please take a look here at the second half of the Sports Game Process & Events Application Form. Most of the events of your application have been confirmed not approved.

Government Staff: If you want to add them to the Uluru Games, an independent application for each event's security permissions is required.

Spathodea: How can I get the permissions then?

Forms. More forms. Indigestible forms.

Government Staff: You need to fill in these forms and take live photos for the events you want to apply for.

What a miserable piece of news.

Spathodea: Ughhhh.

Ezra: Excuse meeee, please, give me the foooorms!

Another tiny figure jumps up from under the counter.

Ezra: I'll take caaaaare of them.

Ezra: Let the giiiirls ... leave and rest ...!

Spathodea: Ezra ...

All the miserable tears suddenly change into tears of joy. She gives him a bear hug.

Ezra: Mmm?!

Spathodea: Gosh, that's so kind of you! You are the kindest person of all the kind people I know! Thank you, Ezra!

Spathodea: I can't promise I'll stay in bed for the next three days, but-but I'll take the medicines in time! No hesitation!

Ezra: No worries, Spathodea. I've also learned something today.

The little researcher helplessly smiles, his face pale.

Ezra: That is, it pains me more to see people suffer than to endure my own suffering. I prefer to give them a hand.

Ezra: Please leave the paperwork to me. I can jump to reach the counter.

Government Staff: Stool. Take another stool over there.

Ezra: Ah. Yes. Jumping for too long would cause irreversible damage to my meniscus. Thank you so much!

Behind the glass, the exhausted receptionist finally shows a smile of relief.

Ulu: The Games and Flammy woke me up when I was still a small flame a millennia ago. They made me fanatic and crazy.

Ulu: How amazing, my young friend. I'm just like the present me when I talk to you.

Vertin: What do you mean "the present me"?

Ulu: An old flame that has been burning for over a thousand years.

Ulu: You are smart, and your ideas are fun. I've been paying attention to you when I was still a small flame. Looks like you have a lot of expectations for the Uluru Games.

Ulu: Sometimes it feels like ... you care about the Games even more than Flammy does.

Vertin: I do have hopes for it. My wish to revive the Games is stronger than Ezra's, and my expectations for it are higher than Spathodea's.

Vertin: After all, we're in a different age now, which means we can achieve much more than a sports game.

Vertin: But to be honest, I'm impressed by Ms. Spathodea's energy and passion for all these. She's ... Huh? Who are those people by her side?

The little girl excitedly walks on the sand, her hands waving in the air and pointing each part of the space for their usages. Behind her, an engineering team follows.

Spathodea: From here, toooo, here!

Spathodea: I wanna build a neat entrance here. I also need a kiosk and a fridge with drinks!

Repairman: Okay. Our engineer will bring you the suitable sample materials before tomorrow 5 p.m. You can make a choice then.

Repairman: And you will see the architectural drawing tomorrow morning.

Vertin: Spathodea, who are they?

Spathodea: They are engineers from Laplace!

Spathodea: Our buildings don't meet the government's requirements, so we have to repair them.

Spathodea: Ezra called them from Alice Springs, and Laplace seems very supportive. They took the fastest ride and got here in less than an hour!

Ulu: Repair? Will they change the internal structure of the Stadium?

Spathodea: Of course not! There's no way I'd let them do that!

Spathodea: The Uluru Stadium is not a creation of arcanists', but a gift from great nature and its noble spirit. All we will do inside is sweat and let our spirits burn!

Vertin: Wait.

Squeak.

Spathodea: Hmm? I think I just heard something ...

Huff, huff.

Ulu: I heard it too ... It's ...

Bunyip: *roars*

Spathodea: The Bunyips! And those Thorny Devils! They must have snuck out from the Stadium!

Spathodea: Ugh, darn those tabloids! We're at the center of the storm now! These things just won't let us go, like some cockroaches attracted to an open jar of jam!

Ulu: There are scraps of paper sticking to the corner of their mouths. Is that newspaper?

Ulu: "MAYHEM! REVIVAL SQUAD OF ULURU GAMES IN CITY HALL WITH BUNNY GIRL?! MENTAL BREAKDOWN OF RECEPTIONIST! Exclusive on Australian Nagger ..."

Ulu: Gosh, children ... What have you done out there?!

5#1

Tea Party

RUG-10

Everything is going smoother than expected.

Vertin: Laplace has forwarded the Uluru Games application to the Foundation, and it has been moving smoothly in the system in the last two weeks. I heard that from Mr. Slouch Hat on the phone this morning.

Vertin: They believe it will be a good opportunity to build a positive image for arcanists, and it will strengthen the communication between them and humans. The Foundation is happy to see that happen.

Ezra: Then when will we have the result of the application?

Vertin: The procedure is long and complicated. Besides, the safety reports were only submitted a few days ago, so it will take at least 20 days.

Spathodea: Twenty days? If we start the construction after that, we'll never make it on the opening day. The engineers said the construction will take at least a month and a half.

Vertin: That's almost the fastest they can do. Can we postpone it a bit more?

Spathodea: Hmm ... I'm afraid not. I already postponed it until half a month later for the construction. Summer will be over if we wait any longer.

Ezra: It's okay. We have talked about the construction arrangement.

A map marked with writings is rolled out on the table. Ezra draws a new line.

Ezra: We may start the renovation ourselves, and move on to other things when we have more people to help. As I demonstrated here, if we plan it properly, we may be able to finish the construction in a month.

Ezra: By then, we can start the event as Ms. Spathodea first planned.

Spathodea: Gosh! I already checked the schedule a hundred times!

Spathodea: How did you manage to cut down 15 days from nowhere?! This is unbelievable!

Spathodea holds the paper level to her nose and has a read.

Spathodea: You're a genius, Ezra! I guess the Games would have died on the vine without you!

Ezra: It's nothing extraordinary, compared to what a real human genius can do. Don't forget arcanists are the pillar of the Games.

Spathodea: Let me see ... Divide the construction team into three groups, one building the entrance, and the other two repairing the internal ceiling and walls ...

Spathodea: ... The internal ceiling and walls?

Spathodea: Ezra, I have never made that request to the construction team. You must be mistaken. We need not repair what's inside the Stadium!

Ezra: I added it to the list.

Ezra: I have investigated the site with some workers from the construction team. The Stadium is ancient. The walls are badly weathered and can barely hold up anything. It has become more of a natural scenic spot than a Stadium for sports.

Ezra: For safety reasons, we might use a support structure made of alloy to ...

Spathodea: No! Definitely NO!

Spathodea stands up quickly, overturning the chair.

Spathodea: This is the Uluru Stadium we're talking about, not some office building on the street! I will not let you in!

Spathodea: I wouldn't have left the gate open if you told me your plan earlier!

Ezra: But what about the audience, Ms. Spathodea? How are we going to look after their safety?

Ezra: If one of the walls or the ceiling collapses, how can they escape?

Spathodea: Nothing like that has happened before, not even one case in the past hundreds of years!

Ezra: Nothing stays the same forever. We have to foresee the danger before it is too late.

Spathodea: They can run away from the danger themselves.

Ezra: Excuse me?

Spathodea: You already figured it out, right? The Stadium can get rid of fatigue from arcanists and adjust their conditions and arcane abilities to their best.

Spathodea: Even if accidents really happened, they can protect themselves. The prophets and diviners will also warn the others.

Spathodea: We never needed metal bars above our heads to protect us!

Ezra: What about the human audiences?

Ezra: They have no superpower, nor super senses. They can't fly a broom or teleport themselves. They can't even get themselves out of a packed room.

Ezra: In your plan, how are you going to ensure their safety?

Spathodea: Humans? What are they doing in the Stadium?

Ezra: ...!

Spathodea: There has never been a single human in the Uluru Games. None of them managed to find the entrance, not to mention enter it ...

Ezra: But I am human, Ms. Spathodea.

Ezra: You invited me to the Games. It's also you who told me that humans, like myself, can enter the Uluru Stadium if it shows itself!

The cup in his hand falls to the table.

Spathodea: You ... I-I thought you were different!

Spathodea: You showed concern about arcanists, and you helped us a lot. You're a kind human ...

Ezra: But I'm not special.

Ezra: I am no greater than any other humans. I don't deserve to be treated differently. I'm just one of the majority, an ordinary human.

Ezra: If I can be accepted by the Stadium, so can other humans!

Ezra presses on the map dotted with red marks, dragging that arc he drew towards himself.

Desert Flannel: Spathodea, Ezra ... Guys, calm down! This is not the time for a fight!

Spathodea: This is not the time?! When shall we have it then?!

Spathodea: The world is full of sports games for humans! One after another and another!

Spathodea: But THIS, this is the only sports game for arcanists! Why don't you go mind your own games?

Spathodea: And haven't humans stolen enough from us? They even made our arcane skills accessible to them. They modified arcane gadgets and added some science stuff and ... Bang! The arcane tricks I know suddenly became something new—some invention exclusive for humans' use!

Spathodea: And now, they're even taking away the Uluru Stadium with metal bars?! It was me who found this Stadium, and I'm not giving it to anyone!

Not to be outdone, the girl pulls the map to her side.

Ezra: Taking away?

Ezra: We, no ... I-I have never thought of taking anything away from you, Ms. Spathodea.

Ezra: I was just trying to help, like most of the Laplace researchers. We spend most our time in the lab, we read, we study day and night ...

Ezra: We weren't doing it to make humans noble, nor for arcanists!

Ezra: Those products and achievements ... They are the fruit of the combination of arcanum and science. They were made to make everyone's life better.

One side is full of sullen resentment.

Spathodea: Make life better? Get out! You think I never saw the ad of Laplace?

Spathodea: "Guide arcanum with science, tame the orderless power with sense." That's what you tell the people!

The other side seems unwilling and filled with grievance.

Spathodea cranes out to Ezra, her face flushed with anger.

Ezra: Sense will guide sentiments, so as to prevent the latter from destroying itself in the flames.

Ezra: You have to attend to the flames carefully, to understand them, protect them from danger ... This is what I've been taught, and this is also the principle I've always acted upon.

Ezra: And this very suitcase that we are staying in is also placed at the entrance made by humans! You shouldn't think so ill of them when you're standing on it!

The rational, delicate boy frowns and grips the pen until his finger whitens.

Ezra: We were only trying to help, that's all!

Rip! The drawing is torn into two pieces, underneath which the table in between seems like the King's Canyon.

Spathodea: I'm out! It's pointless arguing with a rude human who has no respect for arcanists!

First trotting, then scooting and running, Spathodea storms toward the room at the end of the hallway. "Bang!" She slams the door and shuts the world out.

Ezra: ...

Ezra: Sorry, I will go back to my room now.

Head lowered and murmuring, Ezra runs away from the table as if chased.

Vertin: ...

Vertin: It's a nice map.

She puts the two pieces together, but the crack on the paper still can't be ignored.

Vertin: It shouldn't be left in halves. What do you think?

Desert Flannel: I don't like the idea of giving up, and I have never messed up a job once I took it.

Desert Flannel pushes the left half of the map towards the burning flame.

Desert Flannel: I'll take care of this, and you look after that. What do ya say?

Ulu: ...

Vertin: Ulu? Are you alright?

Ulu: I'm fine. I just ... feel a bit dizzy ...

Ulu: My head has been feeling heavy since the battle against the Bunyips, and sometimes even my body feels itchy. I think I'll be fine after I fully recover.

Ulu shakes her head and picks up the broken map.

Ulu: Leave this half to me. I'll talk to her.

Vertin: Thanks, Ulu. I'll request another raise of your accelerants from Laplace.

Vertin: Desert Flannel, you take care of Ezra. I'll follow the progress of the Foundation's examination.

Vertin: Let's move, friends.

The people set out for their targets one after another, leaving only empty chairs in the room.

Bunyip: Ssss ...

A small figure as black as cinder walks out of one pool of shadow.

And then vanishes into the other.

The Australian Nagger Office

Chief Editor: What the heck did you say?! What do you mean "no other progress"?!

Chief Editor: Progress of the Uluru Stadium Renovation. Who the heck will buy our newspaper for this piece of s**t?!

His mustache quivers with every angered breath.

Makower: Sorry, Sir.

Makower: We haven't been able to find anything new about the Revival Squad for a long time. They didn't even step out of that suitcase in the last two weeks after we got their names in the papers.

Makower: Neither did we hear anything from the sources ... Ugh!

A file filled with papers is thrown into Makower's face.

Chief Editor: I'm not hiring a notorious journalist like you for this boring news!

Chief Editor: Get out and find more! Some big and breaking news like that REVIVAL SQUAD OF ULURU GAMES IN CITY HALL WITH BUNNY GIRL!

The chief editor storms off, leaving his lion roar lingering in the room.

Makower: ...

Bunyip: Sss ... SSS!

Makower: ... Heh, it's you. Good timing.

The tiny Bunyip swiftly crawls up Makower's leg and winds around his finger. Seconds later, it turns into a spot of ink.

Makower: The Uluru Games on the edge of total disruption, the Revival Squad ... turn against each other! I knew it, a group of monkeys ...!

Makower: This is fun. The chief editor and that chick will both enjoy this.

Makower: Heh-heheheheheh ... *coughs* ...

His body keeps trembling, trembling, and trembling, until he can't help but let out uncontrollable laughter.

5#1

Glass Slippers

RUG-11

The door is closed.

Vertin: Hi, it's Vertin.

Vertin: Ms. Desert Flannel, is Ezra still with you?

After a while, the door is still closed.

Vertin: Ms. Desert Flannel?

Silence is the only answer.

Vertin: Spathodea has decided to supervise the construction herself, and Ulu is now with her at the site. I'm wondering how you are doing with Ezra.

Vertin: No response. Are they ...

Vertin: Not in the room, I knew it.

A note has been left on the desk beside the bed.

Vertin: ...?

Vertin: "Showing Ezra what the world is like. Be right back."

Vertin: "Desert Flannel."

Desert Flannel: Watch your feet and your head.

Desert Flannel: The people here never look down. That's how you get muddy shoes when you're out of here.

Desert Flannel: Here, take my hand.

Ezra: Ms. Desert Flannel, what is this place? What are we doing here?

Desert Flannel: Something that needs to be done, and something that needs to be said.

The deeper they go, the louder the cheering they hear from the crowd.

Desert Flannel: Hey! Big bloke, don't get in my way!

The big guy steps aside. A ray of light penetrates the air and pierces Ezra's eyes, and the only thing he can see is boundless white.

Ezra: Emm ... this is ...

Desert Flannel: The warm-up of the rugby game. It's not a formal game, but the audience enthusiasm is burning. I mean ... it's hard to get the ticket.

Desert Flannel: But I'm Desert Flannel, and I know people on the streets. Even when we're outside Melbourne.

Ezra: Sorry, I've never watched any games, and I don't know the rules of rugby.

Ezra: I ... I don't think I will understand any of this. Do you mind?

Desert Flannel: No, I'm cool with that, because the game is not what we are after.

Desert Flannel: You see that guy over there? That's Tom, a shining new star in the NRL, the best fullback they've ever had. He's from the Melbourne Sail Car Club.

Desert Flannel: They have a seagull as their club's mascot, with a fish and a chip in its mouth.

Ezra: Yes ...? Okay ...?

Desert Flannel: And that bloke over there. That's Kip-Karl of the Hobart Blue Lake. He's the kind of player who knows how to really tackle. They call him the Unbreakable K.

Desert Flannel: And lastly, I want you to look at that smaller guy. That's Russel. Doesn't look tough, does he? But he is the Slippery Jerboa, because, man, he is fast when he gets the ball.

Ezra: But what is this to do with us? I still don't understand ...

Desert Flannel: Ezra.

Desert Flannel: Guess how many of them are arcanists?

Commentator: Nice one! Nice one! Russel made it again! Excellent interception!

Commentator: The key score! Now the Jerboa is as slippery as butter! Run, run for it, Russel! Victory is going to the Shepherds of Melbourne!

On the green field, Russel is roaring excitedly after his goal. He draws a cross symbolizing victory on his uniform stained with dirt and grass.

Audience: Russel! Russel! Russel!

Audience: Russel! Russel! Russel! Russel!

Wave after wave, the cheer of the audience swells through the field.

Ezra, however, is pulled by a sudden force at his arm and heads out of the Stadium.

Inside a dark and long tunnel, Desert Flannel marches without hesitation.

Ezra: Mankind is known for their physical resilience and endurance, that is to say ...

Ezra: Tom and Kip-Karl are humans, while Russel, whose skills and unpredictability are his strength, is an arcanist.

Desert Flannel: Hmm. A reasonable deduction!

Desert Flannel: Physical resilience and varied skills are indeed the respective features of mankind and arcanists.

Desert Flannel: However, things are not as simple as they appear.

She stops at a door, turns the doorknob, and pushes it open.

Changing Room

What welcomes them is a mixed smell of sweat, dust, grass, and medicine, together with occasional curses.

Players, black and blue, are busy coming and going. Nobody has time to take care of these two trespassers.

Desert Flannel: In fact, all of them are arcanists.

Russel: ... S**t, gimme that thing. *exhales*

Team Manager: Here ... Be careful, don't overdose. Painkillers are addictive, you know.

Team Manager: And the newspaper is gonna interview you champions, so don't get high in front of the camera. Hey, listen ...

Russel: Emm ...

Desert Flannel: Sporting is great fun, but it can also be dangerous, especially for sports like rugby, MMA, or boxing, which involve a lot of intense physical contact.

Desert Flannel: And the arcanists, who are good at healing, will naturally become the best athletes of all.

Desert Flannel: ... 15 minutes, that's all they take. Most of the arcane treatments take only 15 minutes to heal the patient. And before that happens, the athletes would just take painkillers to help themselves get through the game.

Desert Flannel: And after that 15 minutes, they are refreshed and healthy, like those athlete dolls you'd find in the souvenir store.

Desert Flannel: They can slide, impact like a maniac, and don't have to worry about missing any important sporting sessions if injured.

Ezra: This is an advantage?

Desert Flannel: That's right, an unbelievable advantage. But ... are they really as good as they look?

Desert Flannel: Their glory comes with a price. Ligament damage and the irreversible tears keep recurring ...

Desert Flannel: But there is still an elephant in the room. It paces around, making noises which are unfit for the place, like this conversation we're having in the locker room.

Desert Flannel: But on the sports field, where the blood boils, power and strength are the only things that matter. Nobody has the time to stop and ask what we are doing here, just like they don't have the time to notice the elephant.

Ezra: ...

Desert Flannel: Ten years ago, Margret of Broken Hill was invincible on the court.

Desert Flannel: In August last year, she died on the last day of winter.

Ezra: Did she die of recurrent injuries? It's very likely that arcanist athletes who repeatedly get injured and heal themselves would get hurt on the same body part in the future. Their body will become fragile. They might even twist their ankle from walking. Sometimes even break a bone or two.

Desert Flannel: No. She died from an overdose.

Ezra: ...!

Desert Flannel: She needed a horrific amount of painkillers to ease her pain, so much that her body was overwhelmed.

Ezra: This, this is cruel!

Ezra: We have to report this to the Foundation and solve it once and for all. The athletes could have played in a safer way if given help.

It's rare to see the boy being so unsure and nervous. An astonished look takes over his pretty girlish face.

Desert Flannel ponders and looks at him.

Desert Flannel: But what if I tell you the arcanists also don't have a choice?

Desert Flannel: For humans who have the talent for sports, they can win the medals with their physical strengths.

Ezra: So, arcanists have to make the most of their advantages to keep abreast with their competitors?

She silently nods.

Ezra: ...

Ezra: I, I had no idea.

Desert Flannel: I'm sorry, truly.

Desert Flannel once again puts her hand on his shoulder and pulls the boy into her arms in a sisterly embrace.

Desert Flannel: I didn't mean to make you feel guilty, nor did I deliberately put you in pain. But Ezra, I was once one of them. I used to live on the prize money.

Desert Flannel: I'm only telling the truth. It is happening every day, every moment, and every second. Drug addiction, premature senility, and irreversible physical damage ... This is almost a destined end for every arcanist athlete.

Desert Flannel: And nobody is held accountable for this, not the clubs, or the hosts of the games. Drug abuse is a personal behavior, that's it.

Desert Flannel: Those people who are passionate about sports and don't wanna lead a life without them ... I have no idea how they would make a living or handle a quiet life, so I know they don't have much of a choice.

Desert Flannel: The sport industry of humans is generous. They offer equal chances to human and arcanist athletes. But it's also cruel, and the athletes are like the girls in Cinderella story who wish their feet would fit the glass slippers.

Desert Flannel: They have no choice but to cut off part of their heels to earn the glory.

Ezra: This ... this isn't fair. These sports and rules are not appropriate for arcanists. They, they have been treated unjustly. They aren't taken seriously and respected as athletes ...

Ezra: Is ... is Spathodea ... one of them ...?

Ezra: That's why she was ... so furious ...

???: So the rumor that they are turning against each other is true!

Makower: Camera, this way. This is the human representative of the event ...

Ezra: ...! You, you are that paparaz- ...?

Makower: This is not how a polite kid would address others, Mr. Ezra.

Makower: I'm just a concerned journalist who run into you while reporting a rugby game.

Desert Flannel: Watch your mouth, mister! This is harassment!

She covers Ezra and rapidly moves backward, but behind them are still clicking cameras.

Ezra: We are cornered ...!

Desert Flannel: Then we will break his camera and let him know the price of being a long-tongued liar!

5#1

Lone Journey

RUG-12

Vertin: Spathodea, it's not all your fault.

The tools are scattered all over the place, but no one is working at the site. The young girl sits on the ground, leaning against the timber and burying her head into her palms.

Spathodea: No, you don't have to be nice. I'm not capable of the job.

Spathodea: I should've known when I couldn't even fill in some forms correctly. I don't know how to supervise the construction team. They all left and my schedule is in a mess now.

Spathodea: I'm hasty and careless. I actually lost my temper with the people who tried to help me.

Spathodea: And, I also did that to Ezra ... *sobs*

Lowering her head even further, Spathodea sobs and rubs her eyes.

Spathodea: I know he has no ill intention, and he's not a bad guy. Maybe some humans mistreated us, but that has nothing to do with him ... and all the others ...

Spathodea: I should've got out of his face right away! I screwed up the Uluru Games. What I did was not out of friendship or sportsmanship at all. I'm just a nuisance not qualified for the Priestess.

Ulu: Flammy, listen. Come here, listen to me.

The flame flies near her and wipes the tears and snot off her face.

Ulu: Everyone makes mistakes. That's what your mom told you when I was still asleep, remember?

Spathodea: *sobs* Yes ...

Ulu: Everyone makes mistakes, especially young people.

Ulu: We were of the same age in the past. It feels awkward to talk like an elder to you, but now, I have to address you as "child."

Ulu: You are 14 now. Remember what I was like at your age? I appeared out of the campfire, so young and naive. My flame was beautiful, yet lethal as well. I couldn't control myself, not to mention understand others.

Spathodea: But my ...

Spathodea: My situation is different. I said something really bad, and I already ...

Ulu: It's impossible that you make no mistake or do everything perfectly. You just need to face them and learn from them. You stepped into the muddy river, that's fine, just keep going towards the clean stream.

Ulu: The point is, you must know your mistake and apologize to the friends you've hurt.

Ulu: You still have room for improvement and the opportunity to avoid the lasting regret.

Spathodea: Lasting regret? What's worse than what I'm dealing with? I can't think of anything. Ulu, I'm screwed.

Spathodea: Maybe Flammy is a better choice for you than Spathodea. My name has changed, and I can no longer be your best partner, neither can I be Vertin's good partner, nor Ezra's, nor Desert Flannel's.

The little girl asks her question, with uncontainable tears running down her cheeks.

Spathodea: This is my second life, but I still feel like an idiot. What was I like in the previous life? Did I grow up? Did I hurt my friend? Did I have fights with you?

Ulu: ...

Ulu: Remember our fight, Flammy?

Spathodea: Yes, we were arguing who contributed the most to the first Games. What a trifle!

Ulu: That's right. We had a huge fight, over this trifle.

Ulu: We never meant to win the fight. All we wanted was recognition and love, but in the end, we didn't talk anymore. This lasted for several days.

Ulu: Then I tried to find you to make it up.

Spathodea: Make it up? I-I don't remember that at all!

Ulu: Because I didn't make it.

Ulu: You were in the distance when I found you. The next second, you were attacked by a toxic red snake ambushing from the bush. Its venom made you pass out within seconds.

Ulu: The witch doctors stayed by your bed for three days before they sent you to the grave. I didn't even have the chance to apologize.

The dim flame keeps flickering.

Large tears roll down Ulu's face and drop into the fire, evaporating into steam, sizzling.

Ulu: You never grew up, my friend.

Ulu: I'm already an old flame after such a long time, while you are still a teenage girl.

Ulu: So, I'm really happy to see you again and really sorry that we once grew apart.

Spathodea: I see. Thank you for telling me, Ulu.

Spathodea opens her arms and wraps her friend.

She feels tears dripping on her chest, but soon they get warm inside the heat of the flame.

Spathodea: You were in my heart, dear friend. We once burned together as a whole.

Spathodea: No one knows my heartbeat better than you do. I will grow up, as you wish.

Spathodea: I will find Ezra and make it up to him.

Desert Flannel: Ha ... Isn't that convenient ...? Here we are!

Hair messed up, the owner of the voice supports herself with hands on her knees, panting.

Vertin: Desert Flannel? Ezra? What's the hurry?

Desert Flannel: That ... That was ... Hell, those guys were chasing us like crazy!

Desert Flannel: Anyway, that's why we are out of breath. A paparazzi was following us, and as we were running in the desert, we-we ran into a bunch of Thorny Devils!

Vertin: I see. We'll deal with this problem before we talk.

Vertin: Give me five minutes. They will no longer be a problem for us.

Spathodea: Hah! Fireee uppercuuut!!

Thorny Lizard: GAAAAARH!

The counterattack finally stops the Thorny Devils. Hissing and moaning, the monsters turn tails to hide in the darkness.

Spathodea: Yes! Finally drove them away!

Journalist: Two weeks ago, you were in the column WHOSE HEART IS HURT BY FIRE, KANGEROOS AND HOUSING STRESS?.

Spathodea: ...?

Yet another trouble is approaching, accompanied by dazzling flash lights.

Journalist: Would you care to make a statement?

Ulu: That was just an accident! Not a misconduct!

Ulu: F-Fire goes out of control very easily, as it's fire, after all. Young people ...

Makower: Besides, you and your fellow team members were seen chasing after a metal UFO on the back of a wooden horse.

Makower: Rumor also has it that an alien power is behind the revival of the Uluru Games, and the very power has also controlled your mind. Would you run a check-up to clarify?

Ezra: What do you mean? Mr. aliEn T is good and kind. He has never had any ill thoughts!

Journalist: Huh? Mr. aliEn T? Is that the name?

Excitement beams from the journalists' eyes. Countless microphones are reached out towards Ezra.

Ezra: ... Uh ...

Makower: So you've known this alien well. Are you involved in the evil plans of taking over Earth? Are you an evil scientist?

Makower: When and where did you first meet this alien as an evil scientist working for Laplace? What was your first thought of the meeting?

Vertin: The answer is much simpler than you think.

Slouch Hat: An arcane ritual shimmers, silhouetting a figure against the light.

Vertin: Mr. aliEn T and I met in a very simple way.

Vertin: It was in the office of a Foundation branch, New Mexico, USA.

Vertin: My first thought ... Well, "There's a 'UFO' here."

Spathodea: Vertin, you're back! Hmm? What's that thing beside you?

Slouch Hat: Greetings, Ms. Spathodea. I've heard about the legendary story of yours.

Slouch Hat: An Australia slouch hat decorated with a parrot feather is floating in the air beside Vertin.

Vertin: He's a hat ...

Vertin: As well as a helping hand.

Slouch Hat: And greetings to everyone. I'm Slouch Hat.

Makower: D**n it, go, go!

Slouch Hat: Unlike them, I'm sure most of you in the media industry know or at least have heard of me.

Slouch Hat: Slouch Hat flies in the air elegantly, as if its invisible owner took it off from their head, put it before his chest, and bowed to the people.

Slouch Hat: I'm a member of the Northern Australia Rangers, also the spokesman of the St. Pavlov Foundation Australia Branch.

Slouch Hat: These days, the re-opening of the Uluru Games has attracted much focus, and speculations have reached such a pitch that we have to respond.

Slouch Hat: Here I will answer your questions about the Uluru Games ...

Slouch Hat: Starting from you, the ardent Mr. Makower.

Called by their name, the leader of the crowd slowly turns around.

Makower: Of course, it's my pleasure.

Desert Flannel: Haha! Did you see Makower's face?

Desert Flannel: Aah, it made my day. I feel happy! Contented! Overjoyed! Now that we have the Foundation's people on our side, he can b****r off for good!

Vertin: You know him well?

Spathodea: He's her enemy, Vertin.

Vertin: He's your enemy?

Desert Flannel: Ah ... Ah-ah, mind what you're saying! We are not enemies. I don't even know him.

Spathodea: You don't even know him? And he's not your enemy? I don't quite get your relationship.

Ulu: Things can be complicated between men and women nowadays. You're still too young to understand it. Don't worry. You will get it at my age.

Vertin: So it's a kind of experience one must grow old enough to learn.

Vertin: The current life expectancy is 50-75 years. I don't think I will ever reach your age ...

Desert Flannel: No no no! Don't put it like that! You're confusing the kids!

Desert Flannel bounces up from the sofa, waving her arms between Ulu and Ezra to separate them.

Desert Flannel: Alright! Now, I, as one of the parties involved in this story, will explain it to you very clearly. Ahem ...

Spathodea: Wait!

Desert Flannel: A-ah ... *coughs* What?!

Spathodea: Where's Ezra? He's not here!

Desert Flannel: He just went back to his room. He didn't come out when we left.

Rubbing her neck to clear her throat, Desert Flannel nods in the direction of Ezra's room.

Desert Flannel: Are you going to talk to him first, or will you stay for my little anecdote? I won't tell the story again, it's way too embarrassing to tell it twice.

Spathodea: I, emm ... I ...

The girl hesitates.

But kids can never say no to a story.

Spathodea: I'll listen to your story first, and I'll go talk to him right away!

5#1

"Unsinkable"

RUG-13

Spathodea: Hmm ... Lights ... checked.

Spathodea: Width of the entrance ... checked.

Spathodea: Support structure for the ceiling ... checked.

Spathodea: Camera parrot for broadcasting the Games, hmm, very fluffy, so ... checked!

Spathodea walks slowly along the clay runway, under the wide and bright rooftop of the renovated Stadium.

Spathodea: Spare torch for the Uluru Flame, obstacles for Steeplechase, tenacity of the branches and temperature of the red clod ... Alright, checked! Only one more item to go before the flame lighting ceremony this midnight!

Ulu: *sobs*

Spathodea: The Uluru Flame ... Ulu? You alright?

Spathodea: Wh-What's with the tears?! Did I make you sad again?

Ulu: No ... nothing. I just have sand in my eyes ...

Desert Flannel: Oh, sand is common here. It gets into your eyes very easily.

Desert Flannel: Just like when my granny saw me walking for the first time.

Ulu: Young lady, you should've preserved the dignity of this old flame!

Desert Flannel: Waah-ah! You burned me!

Spathodea: ... Ulu, burning hot and energetic, checked.

Ticking off another check in the notebook, Spathodea looks upwards.

Spathodea: Safety factor of the field ... checked.

Spathodea: Laplace ... really did us a huge favor ...

Spathodea: Shame I haven't had the time to talk to Ezra since we had that fight. We were both busy, and when we met, it was ...

Desert Flannel: What? You haven't talked about it? But I didn't feel anything wrong between you two ...

Spathodea: We did make up, that's for sure.

Spathodea: But we never really talked about the fight. It's like you break your knee and just cover the wound up with trousers, as if it had never been there ...

Spathodea: You may feel fine when you jump and run, but it hurts whenever you sit down for a break ...

She scratches her hair and then starts to play with her fingers, a glum look on her face.

Spathodea: *sighs* I wonder if Ezra and Vertin are going well with the patrol.

Ulu: Relax, Flammy.

Ulu: It will be the opening ceremony tomorrow. Our checklist is even more intricately designed than a robe made with pine needles. Besides, the Bunyips haven't turned up in quite a while ...

Ulu: Everything is working like an unsinkable ship at sea. There isn't anything that may cause it to sink.

Spathodea: Alright ... but the last ship that claimed to be "unsinkable," um, what was it called ... um ...

The stone door is opened without warning from behind the thinking girl.

Spathodea: Oh! I got it!

Ezra: We have an emergency!

Spathodea: It's called the Titanic!

Audience: I've bought tickets! Let me in!

Audience: I came all the way here just for the Uluru Games, because you said that it is open to all for the first time!

Makower: Everyone, please be patient.

Holding a microphone, Makower stands on a pile of rocks, making him stand out from the group.

The whirlwind brought up by the airship only makes the travelers' steps more staggered.

Makower: We are now standing at the entrance to the Uluru Stadium, and this is where the rumored "reincarnator" will come with flames and bring about the rain!

Makower: The rain will comfort the thirsty travelers and soothe their dry heels!

Makower: I guarantee you, as the ambassador of the Games, that no matter what your lineage is, you are welcome here as long as you have a ticket! All you need to do is wait patiently and with sincerity!

Audience: Sincerity? We've followed the guide and circled around the desert for a whole day!

Audience: We need water and food! Some kids have become dehydrated!

Audience: Yes! We need water! We need to get into the Uluru Stadium! You've promised us!

Audience: We need water! We need to get into the Uluru Stadium!

Audience: We need water! We need to get into the Uluru Stadium!

Makower: That's right, yes, that's right.

Makower: Revival Squad, I'm sure you will enjoy this gift from me.

Audience: We need water! We need to get into the Uluru Stadium! We need water! We need to get into the Uluru Stadium!

Getting louder and louder, the rumble shakes the whole desert.

And echoes above the giant rock.

Spathodea: Gosh!!! It's him, that guy!!

Spathodea: How shameless! We never sold a single ticket or invited so many outsiders to the Games! How can they tell such a lie?!

Vertin: He's whipping up public opinion—just his greatest strength.

Vertin: I took a glance at the crowd. There are at least 3,500 of them out there.

Vertin: Not a number Makower can incite alone. Some of them must be his accomplices. I'm sure they are good at mobilizing, swindling, blackmailing and stuff ...

Desert Flannel: It's the Eucalyptus Brotherhood! The leader is one of them. I know his face!

Desert Flannel: D**n it! Seems like they're not going to make this easy for me, since I took their tickets. And there's Makower—how convenient for them!

Spathodea: We can't just leave them here. Outside the Stadium, they have no food or shelter. They will suffer sunstroke in no time!

Desert Flannel: How are you going to handle this?

Spathodea: Desert Flannel, do you still have those fake tickets?

Desert Flannel: Yeah, why?

Spathodea: Sell them.

Desert Flannel: Excuse me?! I thought you knew that I'm not doing this for money. I'm doing it for ...

Spathodea: I know why you need money.

Spathodea: You have always wanted to buy the house where your grandmother spent her life and raised you. It's important to you, just like the Uluru Games to me and Ulu.

The young girl stands up.

Spathodea: Ezra, Vertin, please contact the Foundation for help. Desert Flannel, I need you to prepare to guide the crowd and maintain order!

Ezra: Spathodea, you're not planning to ...

Spathodea: Let's go all out, mates.

Spathodea: I am going.

Holding the Ulu soaked in tears in her arms, Spathodea shakes off Desert Flannel's sweaty hands.

A dry breeze follows after her, kicking up the dust and forming that shadowy gate.

Spathodea: ...

Spathodea: Everyone, your attention, please!

The crowd's attention turns, murmurs surround the girls like a vortex.

Audience: Ah! That is the door of the Uluru Stadium! Behind her! She is the girl in the newspaper!

Audience: What? That girl is the "reincarnator"?

Audience: Oh, dear, there she is! And look! That flame! Isn't that the Uluru Flame in the newspaper?

Audience: Open the gate for us, Priestess! Show us the Uluru Stadium!

Makower: Open the gate for us! We have tickets! We have tickets!

Standing above the crowd, Makower raises his hands, showing everyone the ticket.

Audience: Open the gate for us! We have tickets! We have tickets!

Like a summoning.

A tumultuous clamor goes up from the crowd, punctuated by Makower's questioning.

Makower: Look at those girls, my friends! That is Ms. Spathodea and Ms. Ulu!

Makower: The newspapers have been praising them for facilitating the union of mankind and arcanists, bringing back the true spirit of sporting events, and calling them the pioneer peacemakers ...

Ulu: In the name of the Uluru Flame, I swear it's not a lie!

Makower: Of course, of course, you are not lying. You never lie.

Makower: No lies have been spoken. Every word was true!

Makower: A junior student from Melbourne, an old soul, a "reincarnator." What's her attitude, and what will she do? Please find out with me!

The microphone in his hand points up at the sky, reflecting the airship's spotlight glaring down at Spathodea.

Spathodea: ... Uh ...

Scattering audio photos fall from the sky.

"Photos": "Humans? What are they doing in the Stadium?"

People hear Spathodea's voice crystal clear.

"Photos": "The world is full of sports games for humans! One after another and another!"

"Photos": "Guide arcanum with science, tame the orderless power with sense" ... "And now they're even taking away the Uluru Stadium with metal bars!"

Ulu: Th-That's ...!

Makower: How ridiculous! She said she stands for peace, yet she has never considered mankind's safety, technology, assistance, or rights!

Makower: Arcanists, arcanists ... that's all she's talking about!

Audience: It's the voice of the Priestess? H-How could she say that ...

Audience: Nonsense! It is the first Uluru Games with the help of Laplace human technology. They've been talking about equality, peace and love all the time.

Audience: D**n you! How could you be so despicable!

Audience: All the constructions are built by Laplace! These are all human contributions!

Audience: I'm out of here! It's not the Uluru Games, not the one I heard from my grandma at all!

Makower: We should believe that she's an honest girl. She would never have lied!

Makower: Ms. Spathodea, did you really say that?

Makower passes the microphone to Spathodea, with a celebratory flair.

A Bunyip appears out of his coat. Its body starts swelling as it devours the air.

From the turmoil of lies and distrust, it gains additional power.

Ulu: Flammy, confront it.

Ulu: Light it up, conquer it, and make it burn ...

Spathodea: I will. I know what my duty is.

Spathodea: You are right, Mr. Makower.

Spathodea: I did say that. I take responsibility for every word heard in that photo!

Spathodea: But people! Listen to me!

Spathodea: Those words are wrong, so am I. I am a fool, an idiot, the stinkiest rotten egg in the kitchen!

Spathodea: I've seen countless humans on my way here, from Melbourne to Alice Springs, and then Uluru.

Spathodea: I've met the construction team from Laplace, the receptionist at the City Hall, the considerate doctors, and ... and my first human friend, my good friend!

Spathodea: In the past, I saw humans as "the other kind." I thought they were unreasonable, cruel people who deceive others with bureaucratic jargon ...

Spathodea: But now, when I think of humans, I'm reminded of ...

Spathodea: Of ...

Spathodea: Of my friend, my gentle, brave, smart, selfless, clumsy human friend.

Makower: Wh-What? Are you going to ...?!

Ulu: Confront it, light it up, conquer it, and make it burn for you.

The flame lit by Ulu burns all the way to a crawling Bunyip.

In an instant, the only thing left on the red soil is burned ashes. The Bunyip didn't even make a sound.

Bunyip: Ahh ... AHHH!!

The rest of the Bunyips scatter. Fleeing into the crowd and corners, causing a chorus of screams.

Spathodea: And I'm willing to believe, everyone here loves sports as much as I do.

Spathodea: I must apologize for being an idiot with such a narrow view. I'm sorry.

Spathodea: Now, I hope everyone can enjoy pure sports and have fun sweating!

Spathodea: Those of you who have tickets, please enter the Stadium in order!

Spathodea: Those of you with no tickets, you can buy one from Ms. Desert Flannel for just one dollar!

Spathodea: I hereby declare the opening of the Uluru Games!

The gate is already open. Flammy puts her arms in the air as the crowd cheers.

Spathodea: Everyone is welcome!

Makower: D**n it! How come ... The source has confirmed the rift between them!

Makower: Run, if I'm fast enough, there is still a chance.

Grabbing the camera tightly, Makower and his team hurry out of the crowd in a panic.

Desert Flannel: Or maybe, you don't deserve that chance at all.

A wall of people stand at the exit.

Vertin: We've got a helping hand.

Ezra: More than one hand.

Desert Flannel: Aha ...!

Desert Flannel: This is what we call "the hammer of justice."

Desert Flannel: Take that, you s****y little long-tongue pig. I will pull your tongue out through one of your eye sockets. You should have known better than to mess with me.

5#1

The Epic of Runners

RUG-14

Vertin: The audience are all seated. No stampede or jostle, not to mention injury.

Ezra: All the human athletes have registered, and their mixed sporting events with arcanist athletes have been properly planned and are ready to start in three days!

Desert Flannel: Aah! I'm done. I can't even move a finger right now.

This is almost a miracle.

Everyone is running, running, and running for the tremendous workload, like a python trying to digest an elephant. Fortunately, they manage to complete all the work just on time.

Ulu: Come on, Flammy.

Ulu: It's our turn.

Spathodea: ...!

Spathodea: Hah ... Haha, again we walk on this glorious path together, Ulu!

Ulu: Run.

Ulu: Get yourself running, child.

Ulu: Light up the Uluru torch, as you have promised!

Spathodea: As ... I have promised!

Her ribs tremble excitedly as Spathodea's heart flutters like a bird, now flapping its wings to fly away.

Tired as her body is, the way Spathodea runs is as lively as her heart.

Spathodea: I am running. Even though the day I last ran here was a thousand years ago, it feels just like yesterday to me.

Spathodea: I run across the long track, stepping on the burning red soil. I am sweating, like a sparkling star! I am going to the top of the Stadium to light up the torch ...

Spathodea: Ulu, Ulu!

Spathodea: Have I grown up like you wished for me? Am I a new and different me now?

Cheers, songs, whistles, and clicks encourage the girl forward.

She runs as fast as she can, calling out.

Spathodea: This is just a moment of my life, but I know you've waited a million days and nights for it! I want you to be proud! I want you to be happy!

Ulu: My friend, my dear friend!

Ulu: You're my Flammy, but you're so much more than that ...

Ulu: You're also my Spathodea ... My little girl ...!

Ulu: You have grown up, as I have dreamed of countless times. The snakes here didn't lay a single tooth on you. Both your body and mind are intact.

Audience: Hey, what's that? The Uluru Flame is dropping water!

Ulu: *sobs*

Ulu: *cries out loudly*

Spathodea: U-Ulu?!

The flame is put out by her tears. The little Priestess stops running subconsciously, which makes her lose her balance.

She falls forward to the ground.

Audience: Flame! The Uluru Flame! It's ...!

Audience: It's-It's the kid of Laplace!

Ezra: ...!

Audience: Flame! The Uluru Flame! It's lit up again!

The flame that revives is burning in their joined hands, feeling warm and comfortable.

Ezra finally hears the people's cheers as he looks around at a loss.

Ezra: We ... we did it!

Ezra: The opening ceremony took place just as we planned!

Spathodea: Yes, YES! We made it! Thank you, Ezra!

Spathodea holds the weak Ulu gently while holding the boy in her arms.

Spathodea: The flame is burning in your hand. You ... You share the same thought, don't you? It wouldn't have burned on you if you weren't wishing for the Games sincerely!

Ezra: Yes, I, I do. I want it to be a successful event.

Ezra: It's important to you, and so to us now.

Ezra: With a smile on his face, Ezra holds Spathodea's hand and lifts it in the air.

Ezra: Mankind and arcanists who are here with us or following the event through radio, TV, or internet, I invite you to witness the blazing of the Uluru torch.

Ezra: She is Ulu, the noble spirit of peace, hard work, and competition.

Ezra: In the past thousands of years, the holy fire has been to the highest mountain and touched the rocks in the deepest sea, taking the peace and all other noble qualities to every corner of this world.

Ezra: It was also brought out of this world, into space by rockets, and traveled among the stars. From ships, to spaceships, from one hand to another, it has journeyed far.

Spathodea: And now, for the first time, the torch to be lit has come to the flame.

Spathodea: The flame is burning in the joint hands of human and arcanist.

Spathodea&Ezra: We hereby swear we shall forget the hatred, conflict, turbulence, and chaos of the past.

Spathodea&Ezra: We shall run in the name of sportsmanship. We shall walk in the original form of men.

Spathodea&Ezra: We shall compete against each other, not for victory but for participation.

5#1

The Uluru Guardians

RUG-15

Ezra: So, did Ms. Desert Flannel go to the hospital to visit Mr. Makower?

Spathodea: Yeah! She bought all the magazines with that photo and brought them to ... Oh, wait, I guess you don't know the story between Desert Flannel and Makower.

Ezra: No idea. I was in my room pondering what happened that day.

Spathodea: ...

Ezra: ...

Desert Flannel: Don't, don't look at me like that! I've told you I will never repeat that story again!

Ezra: OK, I guess it doesn't matter if I never had the chance of hearing it. It's just a story.

It is very hard to disappoint a child like that.

Throwing her hands in the air, Desert Flannel declares her defeat. She makes some space and pats the seat beside her.

Desert Flannel: Fine! I will, I will tell it to you! Come over here, kid.

Ezra: You are so kind!

Ezra sits beside Desert Flannel and waits like a quiet kitten.

Desert Flannel: You must all know that I have many jobs. These part-time jobs eat away most of my time, but the clients who gave me these jobs never let me go home empty-handed.

Desert Flannel: If you were me, you'd know that ... if you are willing enough to take as many jobs as possible, you'd meet some strange clients.

Desert Flannel: Like going to a School Day pretending to be someone's mom, or ...

Desert Flannel: Braiding the hair of a punk hound in 302 pigtails for a blind man.

Desert Flannel: Or, waiting for a rare bird at midnight, carrying a camera which was expensive enough to pay for my apartment.

Ezra: I know. Sometimes, my colleagues in Laplace would also hire others to help collect information they need.

Ezra: But if we have the time, most of us would prefer to take a walk in the forest and try our luck.

Desert Flannel: Yes, that's exactly what my client said.

Desert Flannel: He paid me well for the job, so generous that I stared at the dark and waited for that Pink Torch Hummingbird to show up, despite my bloodshot eyes.

Desert Flannel: One day, two days, and three days passed.

Desert Flannel: I didn't even see anything like it.

Desert Flannel: But I saw a wonder beast, just as extraordinary as the Hummingbird.

Pausing for a second, Desert Flannel takes a deep breath.

Desert Flannel: A ... Pink Glittering Platypus.

Ezra: Pink Glittering Platypus?

Desert Flannel: It's pink, and it's glittering, and who knows whether Pink Torch Hummingbird is a strange nickname for that platypus? Of course, I have to take a picture of it.

Desert Flannel: But you know, a bird lover won't need the picture of a platypus.

Desert Flannel: So I sold it to Kidding Fun, a children's magazine. What happened next should be very evident to you, if you read enough bad novels.

Ezra: Is, is that ...?

Desert Flannel: Yes, that's right. That platypus was Makower, who took the Transformation Potion.

Ezra: Ah, but why would he do that?

Desert Flannel: Perhaps he was looking for some fun, or maybe it was an accident. Anyway, according to him, someone pulled out a prank on him, and it was definitely not his own choosing.

Desert Flannel: He quit his job the moment that picture was published.

Desert Flannel: He left his friends and family, and became a revenger, striving to put me into a miserable situation, just like what he has gone through.

Desert Flannel: So, this time, after I made this fortune, I bought the apartment, and every copy of that issue of the magazine.

Ezra: Mmm. Were you planning to sell them all to Mr. Makower?

Desert Flannel: No, of course not!

Desert Flannel: Who do you think I am? I picked him up at the hospital, took him somewhere quiet, and burnt all the magazines in front of him.

Desert Flannel: He was, oh my gosh, crying so loud! Heh-heh, that was pleasant to hear.

On the other side of the curtain, a young female voice interrupts the conversation.

Staff: Ms. Desert Flannel, Ms. Spathodea, and Mr. Ezra, the interview is ready to start. Please follow me to the stage!

Ezra: Ah! Yes! In a minute!

The kids move before Desert Flannel does. Spathodea gets closer to Ezra and asks a question quietly.

Spathodea: Did you get the ending of the story?

Ezra: No, not really.

Spathodea: Hah! So there IS something neither arcanists nor humans can understand!

Ezra: Perhaps we can ask Vertin later. She's a bit older than us, but she's not here today.

Ezra: I think she went to the Stadium with Ms. Ulu.

Ulu: ...

Ulu: The gold-swallowing crowd, the apocalyptic hedonism, and the adventure on the island of numbers ...

Ulu: So this is what the world has become when I was in slumber for all these years ...

Ulu: I have experienced countless rains, and have even seen the rainbow above Uluru, but I've never seen anything like the "Storm" ...

The flame lets out a contented sigh.

Ulu: I can't believe ... it just changed everything so easily.

Vertin: But the Uluru Stadium is still here.

Vertin: I know there are spots with mysterious power in this world. They can provide a slim chance of survival in the "Storm."

Vertin: And the Stadium is exactly one of them. Such a place ... will be desired by different forces one day. It's just a matter of time.

Ulu: Like the Manus Vindictae you talked about. To them, the Uluru Stadium is like a piece of meat to a hungry wolf.

Vertin: That's right.

Vertin: The Foundation has already launched the Uluru Guarding Project. It will be a long-term mission and involves a heavy workload, and the Australia branch doesn't have enough manpower for it.

Vertin: Fortunately, a lot of people went to the visitor window of the branch.

Ulu: They are ... worried about the Stadium?

Vertin: Yes, a lot.

Vertin: They volunteered to station here to protect it, even at the cost of their own time and effort.

Vertin: They have built the Uluru Guardians which consists of 31 arcanists and 29 humans. There are doctors, writers, taxi drivers, newsstand owners, and so on.

Vertin: And they are all among the audience of the Games.

Ulu: Heh.

Ulu: You made it, child.

Ulu: This is indeed a brand new beginning.

Vertin: That's why I want to keep it here.

The giant rock which the Bunyip turned into has become warm on the red soil of Uluru.

No more wet, cold, question, or doubt.

The strokes carved out by gravel and fire run down from the Bunyip's spine to both sides of its body. At the end of each ridge, words are inscribed, turning the rock into a monument.

Vertin: "We shall run in the name of sportsmanship."

Ulu: "We shall walk in the original form of men."

Ulu&Vertin: "We shall compete against each other, not for victory but for participation."

Ulu&Vertin: By both humans and arcanists.

Vertin: No matter how many times the Storm reshapes the world from top to bottom ...
No matter how the times or the lifestyle change ...
No matter how ignorant people become ...
Whenever they open the gate to the Uluru Stadium again,
they will remember the spirit and faith it has been conveying.
Things will change in the unstoppable river of time,
yet the Uluru Stadium shall remain forever.

5#2